Exploring AI startups Relation to Customers Under Big Tech Dependency

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ABSTRACT,

Since the launch of generative AI technologies from OpenAI, AI startups have become key players in the global development of Artificial Intelligence, especially within contemporary digital ecosystems. They act as intermediaries connecting powerful, platform-based AI capabilities with specific applications for organizations and end-users in a variety of industries. As a result, AI startups are increasingly positioned between key global Big Tech infrastructures and the downstream customer market. Despite their growing significance, existing research has largely ignored AI startups as mediators who contribute in establishing and maintaining relationships, creating value for customers and shaping dependency dynamics between platform and customers. This thesis will look at how AI startups manage their relationship with the Big Tech industry while building and maintaining strong, valuable relationships with their customers. Focused on a qualitative exploratory approach, this research will be based on data collected through semi-structured interviews with founders and managers of AI or tech startups. Data will be analyzed following the Gioia methodology, enabling inductive theory construction through iterative engagement between empirical findings and prior research. By examining the interactions of the three digital actors (AI startups, Big Tech and customers), this research aims at building on the existing strategy literature and providing new insights in terms of actions for managing tech startups in the digital ecosystem. The dynamic model that emerged from this study's results captures in one place how AI startups position themselves in relation to Big Tech and users, describes the level of dependencies that are being created and finally, its mechanisms translate these relationships into coordinated strategic practices that help such startups to survive in the broader innovation sector.

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Keywords

AI startup, Big Tech, customer relationship, AI capabilities, dependency, strategy.

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1. INTRODUCTION

It is becoming increasingly difficult to ignore the fast growth and societal integration of AI technologies, particularly as AI solutions are no longer developed only by the large technology giants, but also by smaller and specialized startups that are becoming active actors in the digital economy. In recent years, the AI startup industry has rapidly evolved, as over 500 AI startups were identified as being created from 2019 to 2024 (Rena & Paul, 2025), offering innovative approaches for product innovation, services for creating impactful digital marketing strategies, or even boosting up the decision-making processes for business clients (Tong, 2025). Despite their innovative potential, most AI startup companies are not standalone entities, but rather they are part of a larger technological ecosystem that is primarily controlled by large technology companies, including Google, Microsoft and Amazon (van der Vlist et al., 2024). Recent studies show that these large technology companies supply much of the infrastructure necessary for the creation and development of artificial intelligence products, including cloud support, resources and investments that allow AI startups to create, launch and scale their products (van der Vlist et al., 2023; van der Vlist et al., 2024). Although the access to all these technological resources allows AI startups to develop and launch their offerings quickly, it also creates significant dependency on the upstream platform providers (Rothstein, 2025). Once startups enter a platform's ecosystem, it becomes difficult for them to exit over time, since replacing the infrastructure, rebuilding the technical capabilities or migrating them to different providers can be highly costly (Franco et al., 2024; Wu & Liu, 2023). The infrastructure dependency especially may generate vulnerabilties related to price fluctuations, technical limitations or overall service availability, consequently requiring startups to constantly explore alternatives (Rikap, 2024; Rothstein, 2025). On the contrary, governance dependency may occur when startups are bound to comply with platform regulations and strategic decisions made by the larger technological ecosystem, limiting their ability to shape their own innovation paths (Jacobides et al., 2021; Wu & Liu, 2023). Similarly, data accesability may also generate a form of dependency over time, as the limited access to relevant datasets, changes in data governance and the limited ownership over the user-generated information might hinder startups' ability to their improve models and ensure uniqueness over time (Faraj & Leonardi, 2022; Franco et al., 2024). Despite the fact that some of these dependencies can be effectively employed for innovation and scaling purposes, others might require mitigation strategies for avoiding excessive over-reliance and loss of strategic independency.

While the dependencies on big tech have been extensively explained by prior research, much less has been written about the consequences of these dependencies on the relationships with the end-users. Most researchers focused on macro-issues such as platform governance and ecosystem dominance while much less attention has been paid to how these startups interpret, negotiate and respond to the pressure from Big Tech, while managing their internal relations with their customers. Therefore, this paper will focus on understanding how AI startups manage to build collaborative relationships with their customers, be unique and form their own identity, while still relying on Big Tech companies. The study will imply defining the existing (technology) dependencies between the two parties, the relationships between the startups and their end-users, as well as the strategies used for maintaining an equilibrium between reliance and authenticity in the digital world. Given the complexity of this phenomenon, this research will be following a qualitative methodology (Makateng & Mokala, 2025). Compared with a quantitative approach where the main focus is on numerical data, the qualitative perspective will allow for interpreting the startups' own and lived experiences, strategic and managerial approaches and finally, will allow for investigating the reality of this underexplained extractive hierarchy and further visions regarding the digital ecosystem (Glasser & Strauss, 1967; Makateng & Mokala, 2025).

1.1 Research question

Considering the need for understanding the dynamics between three different actors (Big Tech, AI startups and customers), this research will focus on answering the following research question and sub-question:

***RQ**: How does the dependency of AI startups on Big Tech industry influence the relationship with customers?*
***SRQ**: How can AI startups strategically manage their position between Big Tech and customers?*

2. LITERATURE REVIEW/ THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 Startups

Everybody knows that we are living in a digital world, full of new technologies that are changing our habits daily and who are constantly shaping our behavior. We have developed machineries, devices, platforms and all kinds of softwares that are strongly impacting our daily operations and that bring new perspectives to how we lived our lives before them. With all this digitalization, the world of entrepreneurship has changed too. Business strategies have shifted, managers started to adapt to a digital era, employees rapidly understood that they need to become more digitalized too. But what about startups? Why are they so relevant in this rapidly changing world? Why all the new attention towards them? Well, the answer is simple. Innovation is increasingly dependent on startup businesses that create unique and niche offerings and reshape traditional organizational and production models, while creating ways to provide value (Mazur, 2020; Skala, 2019). In order to demonstrate their relevancy and ability to be successful in the marketplace, startup companies must also persuade multiple different stakeholders, including investors, partners and customers about their viability and relevancy as market entities (Goncalves et al., 2022; Men et al., 2019). Startups frequently operate in an intermediary role and serve as a bridge between multiple actors, interests and expectations. Therefore, startups are seen as drivers of change by facilitating the transformation of broader technological and organizational systems and converting new ideas into products and services that are ready to market.

Tech startups, on the other hand, are even more relevant in the change regime. Research defines them as companies that aim at achieving wealth through the commercialization of technology, through the processes of research and development, new knowledge generation and new market development strategies (Ahn et al., 2022). They typically operate under conditions of uncertainty, and thus, employ discovery and adaptive methods in their processes. That is why research states that tech startups are often viewed as both agile and fragile, as they are the means of entering new markets, but they are also exposed to a very high failure rate (Subrahmanya, 2022). Additionally, a subset of tech startups is formed by the AI startup industry. Researchers define such companies as newly established ventures whose core values are built around the development, application, or commercialization of artificial intelligence technologies, such as machine learning, data analytics and automated decision-making

systems (Schulte-Althoff et al., 2021). Unlike traditional tech firms, AI startups typically rely on continuous data processing and model refinement, making technological integration and adaptation central to their operations. It is worth mentioning that this industry is rapidly growing and has expanded dramatically in the recent years, with tens of thousands of ventures now active worldwide and thousand more being founded every year. Two standouts from this rapidly growing industry are the European AI companies Lovable and Mistral AI. While Lovable enables users to build web applications from natural-language prompts with the aim of making programming more accessible and collaborative (Shkutnik, 2026), Mistral AI takes a more complex route by developing their own LLMs and gen AI technologies, with the focus on transparency, customizable AI and sovereignty, as an alternative to the systems developed by the Big Tech (van Weelie, 2025). Research states that it became a phenomenon, especially since the rise of generative AI technologies such as OpenAI that facilitated the growth of AI startups up to 212 000 current AI companies, with roughly 62 000 of which classified specifically as AI-related startups (Tamanna, 2025).

2.2 Relational understanding of technology (and organizational interdependency)

In order to understand the dependencies that AI startups have in relation to Big Tech industry, we must first concentrate on the relational understanding of technology. Recently, studies started to challenge the traditional view of technology, previously seen as a fixed and independent entity that can be easily purchased, utilised and managed by companies when developing the next version of their products. Consequently, recent papers suggest that technology should be viewed relationally, as it is not an artefact that can simply be created, but it is formed and maintained through multiple changing interactions between organisations, data, users and social and professional networks (Pakarinen & Huising, 2023). This perspective is especially applicable in today's world of artificial intelligence, where technical developments or capabilities will rarely be developed or operated in isolation, but will be distributed across a complex ecosystem of multiple actors working together. A relevant contribution on this perspective is given by Faraj and Leonardi (2022) who propose a foundational reframing of technology by not viewing it as a merely finite object, but instead as a continuously developing set of socio-material relationships. From this perspective, technologies are therefore formed by the configurations (organisational, institutional and infrastructural arrangements) and they are shaped by the processes of organising and planning for success. Faraj and Leonardi (2022) distinguish between two types of relations: relations of exteriority, where components and products can be combined and substituted, and relations of interiority, where components can exist only in the context of their socio-material relationship and have no meaningful existence outside of it. Those being mentioned, when referring to technologies, especially when talking about AI technologies, they often fall into the "relation of interiority" category, as they are constructed in such a way that any alteration to one or more individual elements will affect the entire socio-material system. This implies that firms do not truly "own" their AI technologies, but rather they are involved in collaborative, distributed technological systems that transcend the boundaries of individual firms (Faraj & Leonardi, 2022).

Franco et al. (2024) extend the discussion by explicitly theorizing the power and dependency within digital ecosystems. Using aspects of dependency theory, the researchers illustrate that digital technologies create structural asymmetries between firms and, with respect to artificial intelligence and platform-based capitalistic trends, dependency is not only contractual, but also includes significant technological and social attachments. Therefore, it is argued by Franco et al. (2024) that these forms of attachments deepen over time as digital firms grow to create larger amounts of data and complex forms of infrastructural knots, which makes it increasingly expensive or impractical for smaller actors to exit these relationships. In other words, while firms may establish themselves as dominantly positioned through their relationships with users, they may also simultaneously be dependent on large technology firms that provide foundational infrastructures (Franco et al., 2024). These layers of dependency also strongly relate to AI startups, who represent a significant amount of intermediary companies between powerful platform owners and consumers. Taken together, these views suggest that technology should be seen as a dynamic ecosystem, that is ruled by networks and interactions.

2.3 Startups and Big Tech Industry

Now that it has become clear that technology can be defined as a network web that is full of dynamism, where social actors are interacting with each other, it is important to understand the relationships created in this digital and unpredictable sector. There is a growing consensus among researchers that AI ecosystems favor dynamism, where smaller ventures co-create value alongside the tech orchestrators and innovation is achieved through specific (technological) capabilities (Jacobides et al., 2021; Rikap, 2024). However, for the sake of this research, it is crucial to explicitly describe how digital startups in particular are choosing to develop a relation with the Big Tech giants and what are the main reasons behind this choice. Current research states that there are three main reasons for which (AI) startups reach out to the ecosystem's orchestrators, namely resource scale, market access and financial benefit (Gupta et al., 2025).

Resource scale. Probably the main driver for reaching out to a Big Tech firm, the advantage of having access to resources represents a big head start for digital startups. Since developing, training and deploying AI products often requires massive computing power (which most startups cannot afford on their own), many Big Tech companies provide scalable cloud-based platforms along with trained AI models and environments that allow new ventures to prototype, test and also deploy their solutions, without investing heavily into their own physical infrastructure (Jacobides et al., 2021; Rikap, 2024). As a result of these resources and platforms, startups have the ability to go from prototypes to full deployment quickly, thereby decreasing their time-to-market and creating fewer obstacles to entry into the market (van der Vlist et al., 2024). Moreover, startups may benefit of secured access to early developments, as it can be seen in the Microsoft's investment in OpenAI in its early stages, that granted an exclusive license to GPT-3 (Rikap, 2024). By keeping their products within the orchestrators' cloud infrastructures, startup entrepreneurs are able to operate at scale that would otherwise be impossible to achieve on their own, at least during the initial developmental stage.

Market access. As stated previously, Big Tech players guarantee a fast and efficient entry into the market for the "smaller players". A larger technology company can give startups access to enormous pools of users, developers and enterprise customers, allowing them to enter new markets where they would not be able to enter otherwise (Oehmichen et al., 2023). Market access is critical to these new businesses because of the intensely competitive nature of AI and how quickly the market is evolving (Kaggwa et al., 2023). Moreover, the establishment of credibility

and reliability with potential customers can reduce uncertainty by associating with a reputable technology provider. This legitimizing factor is of utmost importance to startups in artificial intelligence, particularly since their target customers often have limited understanding of AI technologies and, therefore, are looking forward to the most reliable platforms (Rikap, 2024).

Financial benefit. By connecting with Big Tech firms, startups can eliminate the large upfront expense associated with capital-intensive infrastructure investments (Auer et al., 2025). For startups that are cash constrained and seeking to increase their revenues, this unique financial flexibility from their partnerships is critical. Additionally, there are also possibilities in terms of access to additional financial incentives associated with the relationship such as cloud credits, technical support and co-funding programs that support the growth of the startup. A good example is Amazon who is giving free credits for startups to purchase their cloud services (Rikap, 2024). All of these financial incentives add to a startup's financial runway and free-up funds for product development, acquiring customers or expanding their organisation in other ways. Although such services bring numerous and relevant benefits to the startups, we cannot say that Big Tech companies have zero gains in these situations. They are strategically choosing to collaborate with startups because they bring capabilities that can be adopted internally in their firms (Gupta et al., 2025).

2.3.1 Dependency on Big Tech

Even if the associations of AI startups with Big Tech are beneficial and crucial for startups, they also create dependencies. Due to their integration of large technology companies' infrastructure, platforms and services into their core business, early-stage AI firms are inevitably linked to the cores of the Big Tech. Hence, it becomes increasingly difficult for the early-stage AI firm to break away from and replace those technologies. What begins as a business relation for maximizing efficiency and scale can become a dependency on the technology provider that limits the technological and strategic options available to the early-stage AI firm based upon the decisions, standards and governance of the larger technology company. Therefore, in this section we will explain the dependencies that are being created when dealing with these kinds of partnerships, as well as their possible consequences. Current research has discovered four different types of dependencies:

Technological and infrastructural dependency (Franco et al., 2024)

The degree to which AI startups are dependent on large technology companies is expressed in two dimensions: the technological and the infrastructural dimensions, as well as their reliance on those. To develop advanced AI systems, an organization must possess enough computational power to support several different types of AI applications and continually maintain the systems that are operating (Hou, 2024; Sastry et al., 2024). Thus, startups usually do not have access to the best or the most sophisticated technologies that are required for developing and implementing advanced AI applications, so they will have a significant amount of their technical resources and capabilities tied up in integrating the Big Tech infrastructure into their products (Franco et al., 2024). This integration allows the startups to leverage these technologies as resources for their own benefit, which is why this form of dependency is born mainly from the need of resources, mentioned in the previous section as a reason for why startups choose to partner up with a bigger company. However, it is quite evident that the startups lose a degree of technological independence because they are increasingly dependent on Big Tech for additional resources. As time goes by, the products offered by a given startup may be tied to specific platforms or infrastructures, creating complex barriers to substitution or disengagement from the platform. Even if a startup starts to grow, it is still tied up to its initial Big Tech investor, as it can be shown in a recent study by Franco et al. (2024). The company Mercado Libre has to pay an "intellectual rent" to its Big Tech partner in order to have access to its technology, which makes it dependent on the collaboration in order to function. Thus, the AI startup's dependency is in a relational sense, rather than in a purely technical sense. The ongoing agreement that is maintained with Big Tech influences not only the methods that AI startups use to create their product, but also the manner in which AI products will develop over time as well.

Investment dependency

The second form of dependency discovered by researchers is related to the investments and financial gains. AI startups frequently depend on large IT companies for financing, just as they do for technology infrastructure. This dependency comes from the need of capital that usually all startups have at the beginning, this being a reason in the first place for why startups choose to align with Big Tech, as stated in the previous section. In addition to providing technology resources and access to platform capabilities, the majority of large digital firms have become formal investors through either corporate venture capital entities or through informal partnerships with small startups, both of which provide a source of capital (Ubarhande & Vanarse, 2024) . A recent study by Xie and Zhou (2023) shows that the investments from big technology giants not only provide a good funding, but also enhance innovation, with leading to a 62% increase in AI patent applications and a 56% increase in software. While these investment opportunities are important for the long-term survival of AI startups, investing adds additional layers of reliance to the relationship between large IT firms and small startups. The relationship between investment dependency and AI startups emerges because, as startups grow, their financial stability, growth trajectory or future funding opportunities become highly dependent on the continued financial support from a single corporate investor. Once an AI startup receives stable capital from a Big Tech orchestrator, this allows them to demonstrate legitimacy and attract additional investors and gain access to knowledge and networks designed to help them succeed. Investments from large technology corporations also limit the ability of new businesses to operate independently, despite the fact that, at the core, without these investments, the new ventures would not even be able to survive in the first place. The way startups make choices, create products and determine company direction may be influenced by contract requirements or other conditions stemming from an investor's financial investments in their businesses (Rikap, 2024). For instance, recent studies show that startups in Brazil and Spain, both financially reliant on Big Tech industry, are also signs of political dependency, which further impose significant limitations on their independent economical potential (Rothstein, 2025).

Strategic dependency (Coşkun & Öztürk, 2023)

In addition to the technological and investment dependencies, current research has also identified the strategic dependency that is formed from the continuous alignment of plans and long-term goals with the central partner. Strategic dependency represents the amount of strategic alignment based on its partner's strategic focus. In other words, it is related to the development of a strategic roadmap that aligns both parties so that both see the

future as one (Coşkun & Öztürk, 2023). In the context of the digital industry, AI startups are usually more likely to adjust their product, marketing, business models and innovation to fit the platform and ecosystem controlled by the tech giant, in order to keep their partnership alive and gain competitive advantage out of it, and therefore, gain a broader market access. While this relationship can increase visibility, adoption and customer attraction, it can also limit the strategic freedom of startups over time (Weiss, 2024; Oehmichen, 2023).

Network dependency (Rikap & Lundvall, 2020)

Finally, the last form of dependency identified is the one associated with the social ties. Even if current business literature stressed out that building a strong and a solid network is beneficial for firms in general and even crucial for startups for fast and efficient expanding, access to resources and opportunities and easy access to market share (Ashurbaev & Shahnozabonu Usmanova, 2024), it is important to understand that it also comes with consequences. In the context of our study, network dependency is described by researchers in terms of how reliant a startup is on its relationships to key stakeholders (people, organizations, resources and opportunities) through the larger ecosystem of related entities that include a dominant provider (Falcone & Sapienza, 2023). When AI startups join the ecosystem controlled by the larger technology companies, they gain access to various networks of potential users, service providers who produce complementary offerings and potential (new) investors (Rikap, 2024). Therefore, while this access opens up many possibilities for AI startups, the actual reach of this network is contingent upon the strengths of their relationships with Big Tech. They are also acting as network orchestrators and facilitating network dependencies. By controlling entry points, matchmaking mechanisms and providing visibility within their ecosystem, Big Tech companies enable a specific pattern of actor interactions, the conditions under which those actors interact and also the degree of prominence they are given (Rikap & Lundvall, 2020). Consequently, startups become dependent on acquiring customers, developing further partnerships and building reputations through platforms. So, it often becomes very difficult to exit and drift away from the dominant network in which the majority of a startup's customers exist.

2.4 Startups and their customers

2.4.1 The role of customers in relation to tech startups

Given how these dependencies are created and managed, we have to understand the role of customers and the impact of their direct involvement. Customer relationships are a key aspect of any digital startup's value creation and viability as they are not just consumers of products or service, but they rather have an active role in influencing the design and technology acceptance as well as the innovation direction (Tung & Lin, 2020). Therefore it is vital to understand the role of customers for analyzing how tech startups position themselves within the digital sector and in relation to their big tech dominators.

Firstly, research emphasize that the customers' contribution is not only about sales, but also about the valuable information brought such as feedback, usage data and contextual knowledge (e.g., how the product will be used) to help refine and create new features for the product or service (Wecht, 2005; Gassmann et al., 2005; Crupi et al., 2022). For tech startups in particular, customers frequently co-create value. For example, early adopters offer feedback to help inform product development (Denoo et al., 2025). In AI startup companies, customer interaction can have an even greater impact on performance improvement because exposure to actual usage conditions and to real-world data can directly improve the performance of the AI system(s) being developed (Gupta et al., 2025). As a result, customer input is integrated into the product's technological evolution, further establishing a relational conceptualization of innovation as a collaborative process. Customers are not only co-creators of technology through their technical refinement, but they also are influencers of how technology is positioned, how it is communicated, and how it becomes integrated into organizational process(es). Customers help define the meaning of technological solutions by sharing their experience with them through usage and are, consequently, actively involved in the creation of technological meanings.

Secondly, besides creating shared value, customers are also a major source of legitimacy for tech startups. When uncertainty is high and technology is complex, customer adoption signals both the startup's credibility and trust to potential investors, partners and other stakeholders (Sethi, 2024). The same study also mentions the importance of keeping customers close, highlighting that the lack of understanding of customer value can lead to missed financial opportunities for the startup. Additionally, when referring to AI startups, the legitimacy mentioned earlier is especially important. For such businesses, attracting customers is a critical success factor in attracting investments, forming partnerships and increasing their visibility for the broader technological ecosystem.

2.5 Relevant factors for building valuable customer relationships while navigating Big Tech

After understanding the relevance of tech startups, their dependency on bigger tech companies and the role of their acquired customers, it is time to understand which factors are relevant for creating valuable connections with the end-users. Building ongoing, valuable relationships with customers requires using different strategies, which take into account both the barriers imposed by the power of Big Tech companies as well as the ability to be more successful than competitors. Due to these dynamics, AI startups need to develop strategies that aim at balancing the upstream dependency and the downstream value creation, rather than trying to create completely independent strategies. Therefore, current research identifies the following factors that influence how AI startups can achieve this balance.

Firstly, AI startups that build close relationships with their customers through iterative feedback loops, customization and ongoing support establish high levels of trust and relational depth which are difficult for others to replicate through mediated channels (Hidayat et al., 2025). Through these relationships, tech and AI startups are able to gain insights into their customers' needs so they can modify their product offerings accordingly, thereby building customer loyalty and long-term engagement (Jorzik et al., 2024). For founders and managers, understanding customer relationships as strategic assets as opposed to purely transactional exchanges implies that, by viewing customers as co-creators of value, AI startups can create greater autonomy at the downstream side of the business while still being embedded in upstream ecosystems.

Secondly, another factor that can help in building and maintaining strong relationships with end-users is the transparency principle, research states (Gupta et al., 2025). The complex, unclear and diverse processes that drive AI technology can lead to uncertainty and concern among the end- users.

Therefore, AI startups play a significant intermediary role between Big Tech platforms and their respective end users. The customer usually interacts directly (and sometimes solely) with the startup that they have chosen to work with, instead of the platform provider, making the startup the first contact in the overall relationship. Consequently, startups must be able to explain to their customers how the AI systems are designed to operate, how data travels through their respective platform infrastructures and how they are mitigating the ethical risks associated with the use of AI systems, even if the technology involved in those processes is not solely controlled by them (Gupta et al., 2025).

3. RESEARCH DESIGN

3.1 Research Design

Due to the exploratory nature of the study and the ongoing observation of the AI startups phenomenon, this research followed a qualitative approach. This approach turned out to be the most suitable for this study since the researcher dealt with context-specific concepts, such as technological and infrastructural dependency, customers as co-creators and relevant factors for building valuable customers relationships in a digital world dominated by Big Tech giants. Grounded theory, as laid out by Glaser & Strauss (1967), represented the methodological school of thought of this study, since the researcher wanted to explore the underexplained relationships between the orchestrators and complementors, in this case being the Big Tech, AI startups and customers. Therefore, the theory developed by drawing upon empirical sources rather than relying upon pre-existing hypotheses (Saunders, 2009). Consistent with this approach, the analysis began at an inductive level and allowed concepts and patterns to be created systematically through coded analysis and comparison of all participants' responses. After being developed inductively through coded analysis and comparison, the analysis switched to the use of abductive reasoning, in which emerging findings were continually compared to existing theories regarding the innovation ecosystem, resource dependency and customer relationship theories (Glasser & Strauss, 1967). The iterative movement between empirical observations and theoretical interpretations allowed for further refinement of emerging concepts while ensuring the final framework would remain grounded with empirical data.

In terms of methodology, this study was based on the Gioia methodology because it allowed a direct engagement with the phenomenon from the experience of the ones living it and avoided the imposition of pre-existing constructs on the participants (Gioia et al., 2012). This means that the study treated informants as “knowledgeable agents” that were capable of explaining and describing real situations for themselves, resulting in theory formation later in the process. Additionally, the data was extracted based on first-order participants codes, that later shifted into theoretical themes. As the aim was to develop a grounded conceptual understanding of how AI startups deal with Big Tech dependencies while forming and sustaining customer relationships, the study evolved into a final dynamic model, known as a theoretical framework emerging from the data itself, that was supposed to explain the relationships between the startups, Big Tech industry and consumers, while exploring possible new factors for retaining the end-users and fostering strong relationships with them.

3.2 Interviews

3.2.1 Sampling approach

The study employed selecting participants purposefully, based on their fit within the research context, since it allowed the researcher to interact with individuals that could provide the richest insights for successfully answering the research question (Suri, 2011). This selection secured interviews with AI startups representatives who could provide answers based on their business experience and current strategies that could later be translated in a holistic understanding of AI startups definition and position towards the bigger industry. Consequently, the data stemmed from twelve semi-structured interviews with AI startups employees, including members of the C-suite such as CEOs and CTOs, and product managers and engineers. Considering the broader concept of AI usage and implementation, participants were chosen from different industries, from sports to healthcare, so that the final data could incorporate diverse perspectives on the topic. The corresponding details of each participant can be observed in Table 1 below. Before the interview rounds, participants received a consent form explaining the purpose of the study, as well as the data related concerns such as the voluntary participation, the audio-video recording permission and the data anonymization that remained available only for the researcher.

Nr	Industry	Registered Location	Respondent role	Stage of development
1	Enterprise software	Romania	Co-founder and CEO	Early-stage
2	Enterprise software	Romania	Co-founder	Early-stage
3	Digital therapy	France	CEO	Early-stage
4	Racket sports	Germany	Co-founder	Early-stage
5	Healthcare	UK	Founder	Early-stage
6	Tax services	Germany	CTO	Early-stage
7	Geospatial	Switzerland	Intern	Early-stage
8	Solar analytics	UK	Founder & Product manager	Early-stage
9	Healthcare	The Netherlands	Co-founder	Early-stage
10	Accounting and Finance	Denmark	GTM Engineer	Early-stage
11	Agriculture	Switzerland	CEO	Early-stage
12	E-commerce	Romania	CEO and co-founder	Early-stage

Table 1. Participants information

3.2.2 Data collection

The study employed semi-structured interviews, since they balance both structure and flexibility, making them the most suitable for a complex and uncertain subject of research like this one (Kazanskaia, 2025). Semi-structured interviews allowed the researcher to consider themes of interest such as legitimacy enhancement, sovereign entity or technological embeddedness, while also allowing respondents to articulate their own experiences in a preferred manner. It proved to be the most suitable method, as the study adopted a subjective attitude, and a fully structured format would have only limited the richness of responses (Orvaschel, 2006). Additionally, the open-ended

questions such as "How do you usually choose to partner up with Big Tech? Could you quickly walk me through this process?" or "How do you see the relationship with Big Tech evolving in the future?" managed to simulate a typical, relaxed conversation, that created the perfect space for respondents to open and honestly reflect upon their own, personal experiences. The semi-structured approach also encouraged the researcher to change the order of the questions or to adapt the questions' format based on the responses of the interviewees, leading to richer data collection (Kazanskaia, 2025). The full interview guide can be found in Appendix A.

As mentioned previously, the data emerged from conversations with startups representatives. The data collection strategy consisted in contacting CEOs or normal employees of such startups via direct messaging and inviting them for an interview. After securing a time slot and conducting the interview, the researcher asked participants for possible further referrals to other AI startups, therefore increasing the chances of finding more suitable respondents. This approach successfully granted the access to a larger pool of participants, from all around Europe and from different kinds of industries, which ultimately created a holistic understanding of the AI models and tools, the different customer behaviors and needs, and finally the different levels of interaction with the bigger industry. It is also worth mentioning that the aim was to conduct interviews until reaching data saturation, meaning that the data collection will stop when interviews are starting to provide repetitive information, without adding novel insights (Magnani & Gioia, 2022). Therefore, if initially the number of interviews was set to 15, the researcher ended up with 12 respondents that managed to provide enough information for a comprehensive analysis.

In the end, the researcher recorded 354.77 minutes of audio/video material through interviews conducted online, via Microsoft Teams and Google Meet. The sessions ranged between 21 and 45 minutes, with an average time of 33 minutes. Each interview was audio/video recorded with permission and then anonymized by the researcher while manually being transcribed.

3.2.3 Data analysis

As mentioned previously, the study adopted the Gioia methodology, using semi-structured interviews for developing grounded knowledge (Gioia et al., 2012; Gioia, 2021). The data analysis utilized an iterative and abductive method to alternate back and forth between empirical data and previously established theories regarding platform dependency, ecosystem relationships and the customer relationship management in digital environments. The analysis did not follow the traditional deductive methodology of applying theory to data, but instead it remained open to the creation of new patterns from the data itself and systematically compared those with established concepts found in the academic literature (Gioia et al., 2012). Therefore, this technique allowed for systematically moving from the respondents' own words, which represented the first-order codes, to defined themes, portrayed as the second-order themes, to finally reaching to the abstract aggregated dimensions (Gioia et al., 2013; Gioia, 2021).

During data analysis, the first step consisted in closely examining each of the transcripts of the interviews. The researcher followed the open coding approach, which allowed for building the first order categories on the exact expressions presented by the informants (Strauss & Corbin, 1998). Consequently, over 120 individual quotes were extracted from the interviews. They were further refined and merged down into fewer codes, as the researcher aimed for avoiding duplications, while keeping relevant insights for answering the research question. These first-order codes retained the participants' own language and views on different topics related to their own strategies and Big Tech associations, which provided insights into the richness of their experiences. Throughout this coding stage, the codes were compared across each interview to establish similarities, differences and recurring patterns.

Then, the second step was represented by employing axial coding for extracting the second-order themes, which captured the relevant patterns from the first-order categories. The researcher translated the first-order codes into initial theoretical concepts and then grouped them together based on similar patterns. For instance, the quotes "If we start developing our models, and so we're not going to be so dependent on them" (I10) and "try to find a strategy to mitigate risks…but unfortunately, there's no alternative" (I11) were firstly interpreted as "Future positioning" and "Navigating Ecosystem Uncertainty". After in-depth analysis, these were merged into a more abstract concept, namely "Competitive co-existence". This process allowed for the first-order codes to be understood in terms of meaning and translated into broader theoretical themes.

Finally, the second-order concepts were aggregated into theoretical dimensions, which represented the pillars of the theoretical model. The dimensions further enhanced the creation of the dynamic model, which was an ultimate visualization of the relationships formed between the startups, Big Tech and final users. In the end, the model explained what the relevant factors are for remaining close to customers and what are the strategies for surviving in the digital sector. Given the complexity of the ecosystem and the entanglement of interactions between the 3 actors, the research consistently returned to the transcripts and compared the patterns, which generated changes in the interview questions, refinement of the research question and finally, stability of the analysis across interviews. The resulting dynamism between the different themes and dimensions can be found in Figure 1 and the complete table of the Gioia analysis can be found in Appendix B.

4. RESULTS

4.1 Data structure

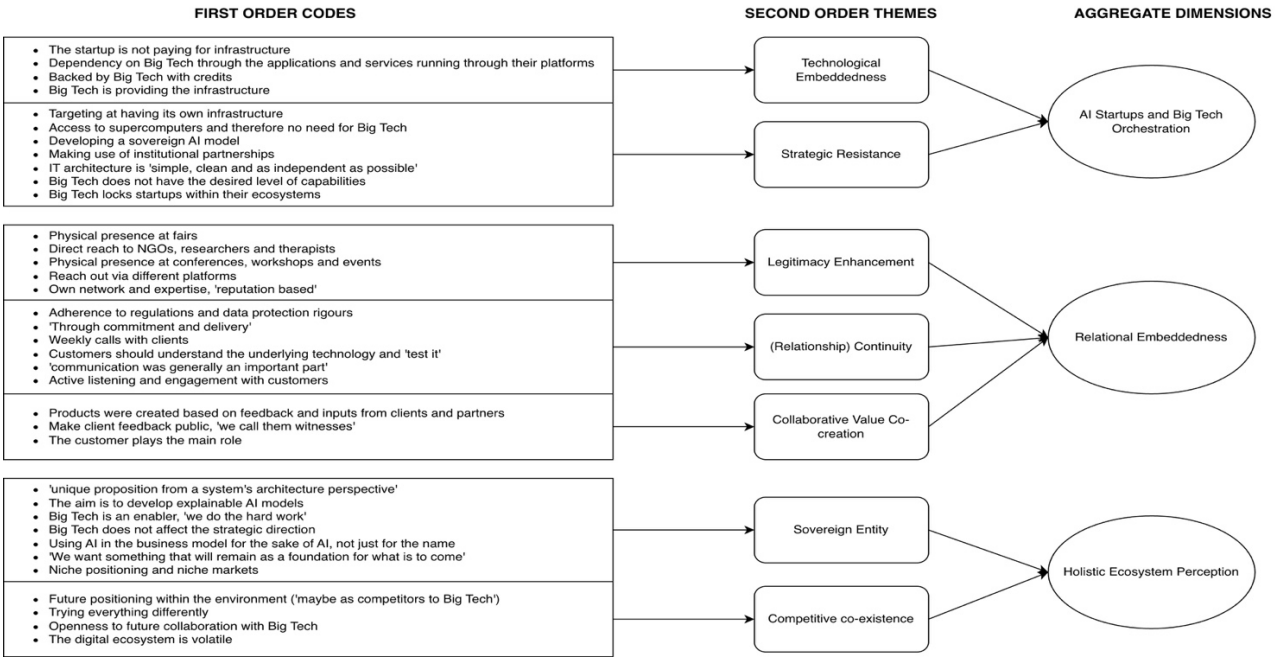


Figure 1. First and second-order codes grouped in dimension

4.1.1 AI Startups and Big Tech Orchestration

4.1.1.1 Technological Embeddedness

The first second-order theme highlights the extent to which AI startups are integrated into the existing infrastructures of large technology companies and how they interact with that integration as part of their day-to-day operating experience. The majority of respondents stressed out some level of dependency on the platform, tools and services provided by the Big Tech industry, but the degree and level of integration varied greatly between startups based on the stage of development, sector and strategic vision. To most of the participants, the support provided by large technology companies represented a functional baseline, an operational condition that was unavoidable at the early stages of developing an AI product. Respondents indicated a level of dependency on cloud-based platforms (such as LLM API's), hardware and other services supplied by large technology companies such as Amazon, Microsoft and Google:

"They are very dependent on big tech, I would say. They have their application and services running on the Amazon Cloud. Their thing works by making API calls to LLM providers " (I07).

Another reason for using the technological resources from the bigger industry was the fact that startups did not have their own in-house AI product, which is common especially for these early-stage businesses:

"We found a company that literally does nothing but exactly providing companies like us that have a hardware solution with also the AI part of it and a really reliable one. Of course, it costs us more to work with them, but it solves us so many issues than we are deciding now " (I04).

Similarly, another respondent indicated that managing an independent infrastructure at this point in time would provide greater challenges than benefits: "But for now, I think that infrastructure is too hard to manage, so we are okay to support the costs "(I05). This realistic trade-off was also experienced by another participant, who explained the difference between their business' strategic direction and current operational constraints, meaning that startups intentionally choose to use the infrastructural help from Big Tech, while being aware and in control of the implications:

"(...) we do not plan, for example, I don't know, to try to build the infrastructure that we already have from AWS (...) It can become a nightmare. We need loads of resources and we prefer to keep those resources in order to scale the products. (I08)"; "I wouldn't say surviving because of big tech. We are getting support on many different levels by big tech" (I06).

4.1.1.2 Strategic Resistance

Although the majority of startups clearly expressed a form of reliance on the Big Tech industry, the findings present the other side of the coin, too. This second-order theme shows an opposite strategic direction, one that is voting for limiting to almost eliminating any Big Tech collaboration, due to ecosystem dependency, technological and operational lock-ins and the potential loss of individual strategic pursuit. Across interviews, participants stressed out their intention of creating technology systems that will enable them to be as independent and flexible as possible:" we made sure our whole IT architecture was as simple and clean and independent as possible " (I03). Another founder mentioned that they "took the harder, longer path in our development, just to make it more sustainable (…) and not to be easily swallowed within the vision of another company" (I02). Therefore, being technologically independent from the beginning seemed to be a decision that was intentionally made for gaining long-term control over their infrastructure ("We want to go in a place where they don't have access currently" (I01)). Additionally, another reason for not relying on the Big Tech giants was given from a capability point of view. Participants

indicated that they were looking for alternative infrastructures, other than the ones provided by dominant US-based tech companies:

"(…) we have access to the supercomputer from the European Union are"; "we managed to build something on European soil without the need necessarily from Google or NVIDIA or Microsoft" (I01).

Additionally, Big Tech could not provide with high levels of specific requirements that some startups were looking for, therefore not representing a suitable partner from a capability perspective:

"if the big tech would have that, of course we would like to use it, but they don't have it. So that's mainly something that we are building some new capabilities" (I01).

At the same time, respondents highlighted the possible lock-in effect that might be experienced when using the help from Big Tech. One interviewee explained how these tech giants "made it in such a way that you actually need to rely on them" (I08), while another one admitted that "they shape our whole architecture…because we need to work within the ecosystem with what we build" (I05). Therefore, by developing a sovereign model and having an independent infrastructure, the startups could eliminate the risk of being limited to operate only within the Big Tech's cloud environment.

While acknowledging the previous mentioned consequences in relation to Big Tech collaboration, startups also actively resisted being absorbed by developing operational partnerships, rather than infrastructural or strategic ones. As one founder stated, large company partnerships were primarily formed for using their specific startup programs, such as mentorships, and not their technological structure: "outside of that, all our choices were driven by simplicity, scalability, and data sovereignty" (I03).

4.1.2 Relational Embeddedness

4.1.2.1 Legitimacy Enhancement

An important strategic factor that emerged within the Relational Embeddedness dimension covered the methods by which AI startups gain their initial credibility and create entry points into their target markets. Across the discussions, interviewees described customer acquisition not as a simply straightforward commercial process, but rather as being fundamentally relational and reputational, involving the need to invest time and resources into building visibility, trust and closeness, long before any commercial transaction occurs. Rather than using existing Big Tech advertising platforms or using generalised digital marketing campaigns to pursue customers, many of the startups indicated that they choose a narrower, presence-based approach, in which being visible and known in the right professional communities represented the main mechanism for initiating customer curiosity.

The first recurring strategy across respondents was represented by the presence at industry-specific events (such as conferences, congresses, fairs, workshops) with the scope of both customer discovery and establishing their legitimacy within an industry. The events were not considered by interviewees to be passive networking opportunities but instead, were intended to be used as targeted venues in which startups could have a credible and knowledgeable presence within their field:

"Our strategy is a lot of conferences or networking events that are dedicated for this market. So, for example, there is a [name of the congress] that happens once per year, and we're usually present there" (I09).

"So that's why we're traveling through whole of Germany to different fairs of tax advisors. Like we've been on like, I think, 5 fairs this year already, and there's like a lot more coming" (I06).

Moreover, participating in these events was not only about brand visibility, but also about being recognizable and approachable at the moment when potential customers were actively exploring and evaluating solutions:

"So, we are at the trade fair and they walk up to us and say, 'Oh, I've heard of you. What do you do?'" (I06).

"I go to events that they host, especially as we are now only in the Berlin area. I have the privilege to be there. And I go to every event I possibly can where I know that there's a chance they're going to be there. And I literally start forming connections like that" (I04).

The second strategy observed was through sustained personal engagement. Cold calling seemed to be a relevant and working strategy, ("we did and we actually do some cold outreach campaign…we haven't tried ads yet, but cold outreach actually works pretty well for us" (I08); "they find the people and they call and then they arrange meetings. That seems to be the strategy" (I07)), but it did not represent a majoritarian approach. Instead, interviewees highlighted network-based acquisition as a crucial approach, where companies leveraged third-party introductions or even their own network circle to make contact with potential customers instead of doing so directly (through cold calling or emailing): "Most of my clients (…) it goes through my network" (I05). Similarly, two other respondents expanded on this concept by stating that they used their own professional networks as part of the foundation of the business:

"(…) we brought our own networks into the business." (I02); "we knew each other from before through the online channels, but we established a bit more partnership during that period" (I01).

This showed that prior connections of credibility could offer a pathway to new customer interest. Additionally, the distinction between 'outreach that builds trust naturally' and 'outreach that borrowed trust' was critically emphasized, as one respondent stated: "If I do a cold outreach, I do it purely socially to people on LinkedIn and trying to connect with them rather than trying to sell them something" (I05), meaning that social connection first, and commercial conversation second, preserves and even increase the chances of customer acquisition.

4.1.2.2 (Relationship) Continuity

One key takeaway was related to how startups strategically maintained long-term relationships with their users by emphasizing trust-building, transparency, responsiveness and nearness. Instead of being reliant on transactional or entirely technology-based interactions, the startups described customer retention as an ongoing relationship development process that is based on engagement continuity and creditability development. Across interviews there was a recurring theme of the need for consistent and direct communication with their customers. Many startups indicated that maintaining consistent and accessible presence during the customer journey was of strategic

importance. For example, one interviewee stated that "communication was generally an important part (…) we tried to be everywhere to make sure we can be contacted in case they need help" (I03). Another respondent pointed out that they have opened different channels for customer communication and active listening of their suggestions, meaning that they were providing continuity and familiarity, which ultimately lead to developing customer loyalty over time

"We most likely have a weekly call with each of our clients. We try to listen to them as much as possible and as well they consistently provide us feedback." (I08).

Additionally, another interviewee put emphasis on the fact that customers "also want to be very close. So they are not there and saying like, 'oh, I buy any random product'" (I06). Thus, developing and retaining customer relationships was not just about product delivery, but also about developing interpersonal relationships of trust and ties. Furthermore, the collection of feedback was demonstrated as an essential strategic tool for maintaining their relevance and increasing long-term product retention. One founder argued that he was

"(...) always trying to build a product around their needs" through ongoing conversations with his customers about their product experience: "I talk with them. I was like, how is the experience? What do you think of this?" (I04).

Another one argued that (I08)" we listen to them what they need", suggesting that when customers feel heard they can provide very valuable information . Similarly, many founders viewed their customers as key players in developing their product. One founder said that they "had to carry many, many experiments to make sure that the tool is customizable enough so that it's well prepared for many kinds of perceptual profiles" (I03), while another stated that:

"(...) if you don't rely on customer feedback, you're just guessing and then you could also just flip a coin." (I06).

Another key aspect of building long-term connections was given by transparency in terms of data protection sensitivity and AI usage. Many new companies have attempted to set themselves apart from their competitors by providing clients with models that were considered explainable models as well as being transparent regarding the process behind the decision-making and complying with European data privacy regulations. One of the interviewees said that "the trust is coming from transparency on how you make decisions, how you got to these decisions within your AI systems" and that their models "are not necessarily a black box" (I01). Another founder highlighted the "explainable, unlike other systems" AI models as a form of trust and competitive advantage in relation to end-users (I02). Moreover, data privacy and data security were repeatedly identified as the two areas of most interest for the clients. As much as they represented a concern, adherence to the adequate rules and regulations from a data protection perspective established a strong asset for building trust and continuity with customers over time. One interviewee reported that customers are "not as interested in the technicalities of the AI, but rather in the privacy", as they are interested in "which points in time is the data anonymized or encrypted, so (…) this is not being exposed to a model or like to an open resource" (I09). As mentioned previously, startups strategically responded by embedding compliance and data protection measures directly into their operating practices so that they make sure customer data is stored securely and safely from the beginning:

"We are fully compliant, not only with the EU AI Act, but also with the data protection rigor across the EU and other localities…this type of compliance is embedded. It's not an afterthought. It's part of how the system works" (I02).

In essence, the findings suggest that relationship continuity was enhanced through authentic and commitment-based interactions, rather than through aggressive sales tactics. Many of the respondents said that they did not engage in transactional selling, and instead, focused on developing a real personal connection with customers. For example, one founder explained: "I never sell and I'm trying to help them, genuinely" (I05) . In the same way, another founder discussed maintaining strong, personal relationships by frequently checking with them to ensure that "everything is working well" (I04). As a result, the startups positioned themselves not just as AI organisations, but more as long-term relational partners who provided value through longer-term commitments, greater responsiveness and higher levels of trust.

4.1.2.3 Collaborative Value Co-creation

Most importantly, the findings presented the customers as focal actors in the startups' products development, refinement and evolution. The participants described the product development process as iterative and collaborative where value was created through continuous interaction, experimentation and feedback between customers and the startup. This collaborative orientation allowed them to align their solutions more closely with the specific needs of the market and strengthen their customers' commitment to a long-term relationship. Interviewees consistently expressed that customers have a huge influence on the direction and functionality of the product, meaning that they were seen as collaborators rather than just clients. One founder stated that " the customer is the one that dictates the features that they need or want in addition to our standard framework" (I09). On the same note, another respondent stressed out that the clients are "the experts in the industry" and "we focus on them totally" (I08), suggesting a strategic orientation that relies heavily on customer expertise to decrease uncertainty and improve the overall relevance of the startup's offering.

Moreover, honesty and trust were built on active communication and collaboration, as stated in the previous section. Participants stated that when customers became co-creators, they share their suggestions in an honest way, which was crucial for further development:

"(...) when they are listened, they are sharing with you exactly the things that they want, right? (...) You don't want customers to tell you that you are a perfect product, because you're not" (I05).

Finally, the majority of the founders started their business with the goal of having the customers as co-creators integrated into their value proposition, suggesting that this was one of the strongest assets for such startups, especially given the complex process of building strong relationships with their users and surviving the uncertain digital ecosystem: "So we do shape each other (…) it's been a natural…organic path in this development simply because we work in these collaborative environments" (I02).

4.1.3 Holistic Digital Ecosystem Perception

4.1.3.1 Sovereign Entity

Probably the most relevant theme that emerged from the interviews describes how AI startups have established and

maintained a sense of strategic autonomy in the broader digital ecosystem, as well as how they positioned themselves as independent, purposeful players in the industry, in contrast to the extensions of the Big Tech infrastructure they were dependent upon to some degree. The responses frequently detailed how they have consciously adopted behaviours to retain authority over their own strategic direction, product identity and market positioning, regardless to the levels of technology integration. However, the nature of this sovereignty varied between participants and included examples of principled independency from an architectural point of view, to pragmatic forms of self-determination that co-existed with their reliance on infrastructure.

As explained by numerous participants, the most immediate example of this independent posture was the conscious separation of Big Tech as a functional and utilitarian resource versus allowing that relationship to be used in shaping the startup's strategic decision-making:

"We do the hard work. They are just enablers that at the end of the day want to sell your product. They allow you to build on top of their infrastructure and products and then the big bill comes up" (I08).

Similarly, other participants reinforced the same idea by stating that "external products don't really affect our timelines, our roadmaps" (I06) and that "the usage and the servers have less to do with the strategic decision of the provider that we're using (…) there's not a huge dependency on that or influence on the strategic choices" (I09). Taken together, these statements described a shared perception of the Big Tech being just infrastructure providers, not partners, where the startups played the role of customers only and the bigger companies could not interfere with any strategic influence.

Additionally, the orientation towards autonomy was evidenced by the approach of occupying niches that large tech firms were structurally unable to serve or fundamentally not interested in serving. One founder expressed this by saying:

"I think we're offering an alternative that is not a one-size-fits-all solution, but rather a co-development customized solution, which big tech will most likely never be interested in because it's not scalable" (I09).

At the same time, from a customer perspective, the founders could notice that the clients are looking to "getting away from big tech", noting that in conservative markets, the Big Tech's size, influence and privacy-sensitivity concerns are forming a disqualifying factor:

"Usually because we're in a very conservative market, customers are afraid to go for these big companies because they are aware that their data can be used (...) They're concerned about privacy (...) it's an argument against choosing a company to be one of the big tech ones" (I09).

The niche orientation is further strengthened by understanding how Big Tech perceives the startups industry. One respondent explained how the Big Tech's attention is targeted towards companies that "they can see a potential in acquiring at some point or are scared of to be in their niche" (I06), therefore, operating outside of these categories does not mean only sovereignty but also a form of structural protection.

Another consistent asset across respondents was formed by the substance of their own proposition. Most articulated their uniqueness beyond technology, specifically with respect to their vision, team composition, ethical orientation and the distinctiveness of the systems architecture. One of them described their proposition as being " bold, ambitious, probably with a unique proposition from a systems architecture perspective as well" (I02), while another one suggested that:

"It's not another fancy name with some fancy ideas. We want something that it will remain as a foundation for what is to come" (I01).

To add upon those, user experience was also mentioned as a form of differentiation and independency. As one respondent stated, they wanted seamless and pleasant experiences for their customers, rather than trying to replicate the style adopted by the bigger industry:

"We want the whole experience to feel as natural and as easy as possible, instead of (...) everything is AI and everything is a LLM, everything is a chatbot (...) we want their experience to be very flawless and very human" (I04).

By having a unique position and operating especially in niche markets, the startups could differentiate and strategically deliver in an independent way.

Finally, developing a networked form of sovereignty represented a focal point as well. By forming strategic alliances with other startups, they were increasing their chances of remaining independent from the bigger industry and developing additional capabilities that were either lacking or needed to be improved:

"Our strategy is usually building a strong network around us with other startups that we know are in very similar or in helpful domain (..) having the strong network around these capabilities is important" (I09).

Building a network in this manner was therefore a sign of how such startups understood sovereignty: not achieved by solitude, but rather through limited interdependent relationships between players who share common values, are limited by similar constraints and have similar incentives for remaining independent.

4.1.3.2 Competitive Co-existence

The second theme that emerged within the Holistic Ecosystem Perception dimension incorporates how AI startups continually assess, reinterpret and strategically position themselves within an evolving digital ecosystem established by larger tech companies, emerging technologies, governmental regulation and sector-specific factors. The findings suggests that their relationship with larger tech companies is not fixed or binary. Instead, they perceived a fluid and uncertain environment characterised by simultaneous co-existence of elements such as collaboration, competition, reliance and differentiation. Therefore, they often put the emphasis on exploring various strategic possibilities to determine their optimal future position concerning larger technology companies and the larger AI ecosystem. Interviewees agreed that the AI ecosystem is "very volatile" and unpredictable and that the change level in technology has led them to consistently re-evaluate their strategic plans and create new strategies: "if I had the tools to redo everything, I would have done many, many things differently" (I02). Similarly, an interesting perspective was the one of possibly becoming a competitor for the Big Tech, which was again led by uncertainty

and further exploring the environment: “Maybe as competitors, maybe we'll explore shared solutions moving forward” (I02).

The respondents demonstrated an ambivalent perspective towards the bigger tech industry, by simultaneously acknowledging the infrastructural support while also preserving the flexibility to make strategic decisions and remain independent. Several respondents indicated that as the startup grows, their ability to work more cooperatively with large technology companies may be unavoidable. For example, one founder stated that:

“100% we're going to become more dependent because as we grow, we're also going to probably get more solutions” (I04).

Similarly, another interviewee argued that “we would still want to keep up that relationship with them. It will be closer” (I06), meaning that startups perceive the future relationship with Big Tech as inescapable in their stage, mainly because of their need for infrastructure. However, this does not imply a possible lock-in effect or a form of deep dependency, but more of an open perspective towards possible new benefits that might unfold and further help for reaching their own goals:” If our startup becomes a scalable one, I see a good relationship. One that probably I know. It will become consolidating” (I08).

At the same time, many founders were also interested in exploring how to reduce their reliance on Big Tech. One interviewee explained how their company was aiming at “moving away from at least US-based big tech (…) towards an European perspective” (I09), while another stated that “ big tech needs to create much more openings like that where they allow new tech to come and disrupt industries” (I05), indicating that, at least within the European AI startups, there is a larger movement towards digital sovereignty, regulatory cooperation and ecosystem diversification.

Additionally, the startups also acknowledged their need to form other types of ecosystem connections outside of Big Tech. For instance, one respondent mentioned the need for building a strong network with other startups from the industry (“having the strong network around these capabilities is important” (I09)) while another pointed out the importance of research-based and civil society organizations relationships (“keeping close partnerships, not only with institutions, but with activists too” (I02)).

These statements together highlighted that startups are perceiving the industry as a collaborative space, where they build their future viability not only through technological capabilities, but also through social ties and institutional connections.

4.2 Dynamic model

After analyzing the findings, the interaction between the AI startups and the Big Tech industry has indeed proven to be an important point of interest for further perceiving the broader digital ecosystem. Although there are various discussions about the so-called “dependencies” that AI startups face towards the greater technology sector, academic research has not yet fully examined how these forms of reliance impact the way that startups develop and nurture relationships with their customers. Consequently, by addressing this paper’s research questions (“How does the dependency of AI startups on Big Tech industry influence the relationship with customers?” and “How can AI startups strategically manage their position between Big Tech and customers?”), this study has explored the nature of dependency towards Big Tech from the perspective of the founders and managers, as well as how the reliance shaped their strategic positioning and customer relationship management. Therefore, the research identified three big dimensions related to the interaction between the three main actors in the industry, namely 1) AI startups and Big Tech orchestration; 2) Relational embeddedness and 3) Holistic ecosystem perception. These emerged from the interviews conducted with founders and employees of European AI startups and successfully present the personal experiences and challenges faced by the respondents, from the start until present time. Grounded in the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2012), the dimensions captured the processes behind infrastructural, operational or relational choices. Altogether, they formed the dynamic model that explained the interactions between the startups and the big tech giants, the relationship formation with the end-user and finally, how these relationships built the startups’ positions and formed their key strategic occupations within the digital ecosystem (Figure 2).

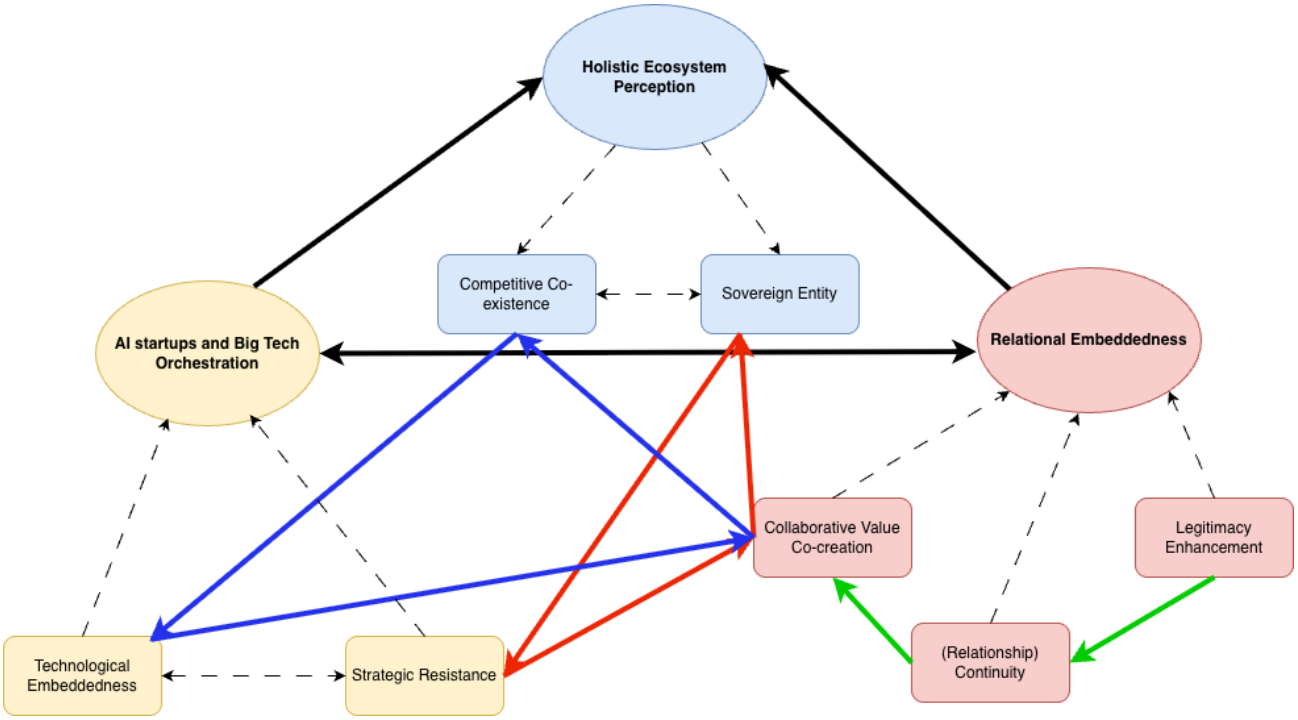


Figure 2. Dynamic model explaining the interactions of AI startups, Big Tech and customers within the digital ecosystem

The figure illustrates a set of tensions and relations between concepts, rather than analyzing dimensions in isolation, which helped in better perceiving the dynamics between the AI startups and their users, in the broader technological context. For better visualization of these relationships, the model was divided into three areas, denoting concepts connected to AI startups and Big Tech interaction, AI startups and customer relations and finally, the AI startups position on the long run within the broader ecosystem around them.

First, the initial part of the model is given by the first dimension, *AI startups and Big Tech orchestration*, and explains the relationship that AI startups develop with Big Tech companies. There are two different, but coexisting orientations to the ways AI startups and Big Tech interact with each other: technological embeddedness and strategic resistance. It is important to mention from the beginning that companies addressed the relationships with Big Tech under the name of "reliance", rather than dependency. While many of the participants stated that they do rely, to a certain degree, on Big Tech infrastructure such as cloud platforms and large language model (LLM) application programming interfaces (APIs) to get subsidized credits from companies such as Amazon, Microsoft and Google, the level of dependency and the reasoning behind it varied tremendously among startups. For some of the participants, the reliance on the infrastructure was viewed as an acceptable and realistic compromise to deliver their products faster and penetrate the market without investing in their own capital infrastructure: "we are okay to support the cost" (I05). For others, the relationship with Big Tech was purposely minimized from the beginning, due to concerns around lock-in, loss of strategic direction and chance of being absorbed into a bigger company's vision: " we took the harder, longer path in our development, just to make it more sustainable" (I02). Nevertheless, the two orientations are not mutually exclusive, as startups often employed the two models at the same time, by making use of Big Tech's capabilities while consciously resisting any long-term reliance on them. This first stage of the model serves as a structural foundation,as it lays out the conditions for such a startup to exploit the resources and constraints that they will carry into their customer relationships once they have entered the market.

The second phase portraits the development and ongoing management of customer relationships and it is operationalized through the *Relational Embeddedness* dimension. This phase captures how startups strategically acquire their customer base and build their legitimacy, what are the steps for building strong and long-term relations and finally, how they perceive their clients vis-à-vis their products. Initially, startups devote substantial resources to establishing initial credibility and market visibility predominately via presence-based (e.g. attending industry related conferences, using their personal networks, publishing in peer-reviewed journals and building a reputation in small and specialised professional communities) rather than through traditional advertising or using other platforms of Big Tech to reach out to customers. The establishment of their legitimacy creates the basis for the initiation of deeper relationships. Upon forming initial contact with potential clients, startups focus their communication with the customer on preserving an ongoing trust-based relationship through continued dialogues about the company's products and services, transparency about the AI systems they are developing, compliance with applicable data privacy regulation and adopting on an attitude of "helping them, truly" (I05) as opposed to an attitude of selling. As a result, customers end up playing an active role in shaping and refining the end-products, acting as knowledge and expertise providers, as they become co-developers, rather than simply passive users. In other words, this phase illustrates how the relationship between customers and startups (and vice versa) is not a consequence of their dependency on Big Tech for success, but rather a relationship that has been individually and uniquely created through direct action by both parties.

Finally, in the last stage it is presented how, as AI startups navigate their place in the larger digital ecosystem, they gain a holistic view of themselves in relation to the companies and users that dominate the ecosystem. This phase represents the culmination of the prior two phases, as well as a new, strategic reframing of these phases. The two themes that emerge from the final phase are 'sovereign entity' and 'competitive coexistence'. In particular, AI startups that have collectively built strong customer relationships through co-creation have developed a clear sense of self (and a well-defined market position) that is explicitly different from that of large tech companies. Therefore, the AI startups are just 'enabled' by large tech companies, are strategically independent and are operating in 'niche' markets that the large tech companies cannot or will not develop products or services to serve. All of these are viewed as current strategies adopted by such startups since the beginning, which help them to navigate potential dependencies and disruptions. Nevertheless, they also understand that the AI ecosystem is extremely volatile and that their future existence in relation to large tech is uncertain. Thus, they adopt an open attitude towards their future relationship with large tech, which translates into a competitive advantage. For instance, as the startups continue to grow and eventually become scalable, they may continue to have an increasing reliance on large tech's infrastructure, but with increased incentives on both sides. On the other hand, they also consider the possibility of being a competitor to large tech or even exploring "shared solutions moving forward" (I02), which is also a base for a strategic plan, but from a different, sovereign-oriented perspective. Therefore, both themes interact with each other within this dimension. The sovereign entity posture enables the identity and confidence necessary for navigating unknowns and, at the same time, the competitive co-existence theme prevents the sovereign entity posture's identity from becoming more rigid by recognising the ecosystem as dynamic, rather than static. Combined, the sovereign entity posture and competitive co-existence theme build a strategic self-understanding that will influence how the startup manages its future relationships with both Big Tech and customers.

Given the cross-dimensional nature of the findings, the black arrows between dimensions illustrate how the interactions of startups with the Big Tech influence the broader perception of the startups' position within the broader industry, and especially in relation to the end-users. Consequently, different second-order themes are also interacting with each other, while not being part of the same dimension. This can be seen through the following mechanisms that emerged:

Mechanism 1: The first mechanism explains how AI startups are gradually strengthening their relationships with customers through three interconnected stages process that starts with *Legitimacy Enhancement*, progresses into *(Relationship) Continuity*, and finally culminates in *Collaborative Value Co-Creation*. Based on these findings, rather than perceiving customer acquisition and retention as separate activities, AI startups strive for building long-term relationships even from the very first beginning, which then enable customers to contribute significantly to the process of innovation and product development from a very early stage.

Therefore, the foundation for this mechanism lies in the *Legitimacy Enhancement*. It can be seen that this step acts as an enabler for enhancing creditability and trust, required to engage customers in the initial stages of adopting AI technology, which may carry uncertainty. Besides utilizing digital methods and traditional marketing, startups place emphasis on direct and physical presence with potential customers. By continuing to engage in face-to-face interactions and being active within relevant industry communities, startups build their credibility, demonstrate their expertise and create personal connections to prospective customers. In this way, legitimacy is not established through technical competence build upon the help of Big Tech, but rather through relational proximity. Additionally, their own network acts as a main source for spreading creditability, which is again a form of competitive advantage from a strategic point of view. Without this foundation, the subsequent relational stages would have no basis from which to grow further.

Consequently, once the trust is established, *Legitimacy Enhancement* unlocks *Relationship Continuity*. Rather than viewing every interaction as a transaction, keeping customers close represents an ongoing process that involves continuous communication, feedback exchanges and full-on support. Weekly telephone conversations, opening up different direct channels for extracting customers suggestions and active engagement allow startups to build a strong connection that does not require sophisticated and advances resources, but just the simple state of being present. Additionally, maintaining strict standards of data privacy, as well as being transparent with customers about how data is used and maintained, allows for trust to be built over time on the basis of confidentiality. Following these strategies further allowed for the enablement of *Collaborative Value Co-creation*. Established trust and continued interactions encouraged customers to become more willing to share knowledge, provide feedback and actively participate in the co-development of products and services for the startup. When startups provide the proper space for iterative discussions, the opportunity for pilot projects and customized products, they have the privilege to proudly position their customers as co-developers instead of passive users. Thus, *Collaborative Value Co-creation* occurrs through both product usage and on-going relational engagement with customers.

Collectively, the mechanism suggests that collaborative value co-creation is a concept that emerges through a chain of relations, that revolve around presence: "I think that presence was something that was extremely valued and was a big driver in knowing that the tool would be used in the long term" (I03). Exposing oneself attracts customers, adhering to clients' needs sustain the trust, and the resulting relational embeddedness allows them to transform from users to collaborative partners.

Mechanism 2: The second mechanism identified shows how the relationship between customers and technology is mutually developed via a recursive process. More specifically, *Collaborative Value Co-creation* enables startups to create ongoing exploration of new ways to interact with Big Tech companies and other actors in the ecosystem, creating a state of *Competitive Co-existence*, and then subsequently causing their *Technological Embeddedness* to increase over time. In turn, *Technological Embeddedness* further proceeds to enable startups to co-create value with customers, thus establishing a self-reinforcing loop.

The mechanism originates from *Collaborative Value Co-creation*. Startups constantly change their solutions, test new features and co-create products with their customers, based on evolving clients needs discovered through close interactions with them. The iterative nature of this process results in startups being exposed to diverse technical requirements and capabilities that typically exceed their internal capacities and resources. For this reason, startups remain open to capitalizing external technologies, models and infrastructures from Big Tech and other similar companies operating in the ecosystem. Rather than viewing these companies as a threat for locking them in or as competitors in the industry, startups adopt a mindset of *Competitive Co-existence*, meaning that value creation within AI

ecosystems increasingly depends upon interacting with multiple actors.

Furthermore, startups can selectively outsource portions of their technology infrastructure and incorporate outside resources into their products, because they are open to working alongside major tech companies. By using cloud, foundation models, computing power and platform capabilities, startups become increasingly technologically embedded within the overall AI ecosystem. Therefore, technological embeddedness does not translate into a simple result of being dependent infrastructurally, but rather into a strategic way of taking advantage of cooperative connections and open ecosystems.

On the other side, it is worth noting that the relationship is not unidirectional. In fact, *Technological Embeddedness* itself also enables *Collaborative Value Co-creation*. When the models' infrastructure and tools are provided by bigger tech companies, they allow entrepreneurs to allocate their resources for creating value for the end-users, therefore to create more complex, customized and scalable products for their customers. Without this technology, many of the activities and iterative products improvements mentioned by the respondents would not even have been achievable. As a result, starting at a micro-level, startups have a cooperative engagement in creating value with their customers which is closely tied to their technological relationship with outside suppliers. Thus, as a consequence of this technological embeddedness, startups are able to facilitate a co-creation environment with their customers that would not otherwise have existed if it were not for the provided technological capabilities: "but let's say tomorrow AWS will not work, then we cannot onboard anymore customers" (I08). Therefore, this recursive mechanism highlights how customer-driven innovation and technological integration become mutually reinforcing processes within the creation of AI systems and applications.

Mechanism 3: The third mechanism is probably the most interesting from a theoretical perspective because it shows how the customer relationship and strategic autonomy work together in a mutually reinforcing manner. While the blue mechanism focuses on technology interdependency and the green mechanism describes the deepening of relationships, the red mechanism shows how startups use close customer relationships to maintain their autonomy and resist becoming overly dependent on Big Technology. Essentially, this red mechanism shows how strategic autonomy is not achieved individually, but instead it is created through interaction between the startups, their customers and other relevant participants operating in this ecosystem.

The origin of this mechanism lies in the *Collaborative Value Co-Creation* theme. Since AI startups engage in close interactions with customers and use these dynamics to create highly individualized solutions, they are automatically targeting to operate in niches that are frequently unattractive to Big Tech companies to consider as viable markets, based on their scalability potential. As a result, startups usually create unique capabilities and value propositions, together with their clients, that are not easily standardized or duplicated by the bigger players. Therefore, this collaborative uniqueness enables the *Sovereign entity* aspect of such startups. By operating in niche sectors and crafting solutions rooted in customer expertise, the startups become independent in setting their own strategic directions, which are ultimately based on their domain knowledge, relational network and not on the technological resources supplied by the large tech companies: "we're offering an alternative that really is not a one-size-fits-all solution, but rather a co-development customized solution, which big tech will most likely never be interested in because it's not scalable (I09)."

Then, because of the *Sovereign Entity* view, *Strategic Resistance* is also enabled. Since startups derive their uniqueness from their specialised knowledge and closeness to the customers, they have greater chances of resisting excessive dependency and avoiding lock-in effects. Instead of accepting the infrastructures and standards dictated by dominant tech players, startups proactively investigate other providers, European-oriented infrastructures, researching partners and potential institutional partnerships, for achieving the desired level of capabilities. Their confidence that they have a unique value proposition allows them to selectively work with Big Tech, while at the same time maintaining strategic flexibility. Consequently, the resistance to Big Tech is not seen as an act of opposition against the larger industry, but rather a consequence of the desire to retain control over technological decision-making and long-term positioning: "they made it in such a way that you need to rely on them" (I08). In the end, *Strategic Resistance* further strengthens *Collaborative Value Co-Creation*, closing the cycle. By deliberately avoiding locking themselves in and maintaining a degree of freedom by making sovereign technological and organizational choices, startups increase their capacity to respond to their customer's very specific needs and adapt to their preferences. *Strategic Resistance* therefore protects the freedom to experiment, boosts up the solution creation processes, encourages the integration of multiple sources of technology and innovates in response to their customers' needs and requests without being restricted by the tech architectures or business models of the Big Tech: "we also developed the model iteratively and gradually based on the experience, based on the feedback, based on the inputs from our project partners, clients (I02)." Consequently, *Strategic Resistance* serves as the vehicle for the protection of the fundamental relationship and innovative capacities that originally created the concept of *Collaborative Value Co-Creation* and thus, enables it to restart the cycle.

5. DISCUSSION

Although previous literature illustrated the importance of Big Tech and their central positions as resources providers, market enablers, financial suppliers and networking sources (Gupta et al., 2025; Rikap, 2024; van der Vlist et al., 2024), this research highlighted a more nuanced and contrasting perspective. The relationship between the AI startups and Big Tech companies was regarded not as a partnership, neither as a strategic collaboration, but rather as a provider-customer arrangement, in which the role of Big Tech was just to provide an ingredient for a required piece of infrastructure. Thus, while existing literature portrayed the Big Tech and startup relationship as being a mutually beneficial partnership with respect to areas such as co-investing, co-developing, market legitimisation and network access (Jacobides et al., 2021; Oehmichen et al., 2023), the results of this study were found to be rather contrasting to this.

There was a consistent rejection of the existing literature's framework that suggested partnering with a reputable technology company helps in reducing uncertainty and provides a signal of credibility to potential customers (Rikap, 2024). Actually, eleven out of twelve participants did not share the view of Big Tech providing access to potential customers, financial resources or professional network access. Instead, the participants developed relational capital independently of the Big Tech companies they used, utilising their personal connections, attending industry-specific events and conducting community outreach efforts: "it was not through big tech, it was mostly us, reaching out to them or through our existing network" (I11). Therefore, while prior

research has concentrated on emphasizing the structural advantages of Big Tech in relation to the growth and survival of AI startups, this paper shifted the view, indicating that such startups build their own relational and strategic assets, even though the broader ecosystem is still controlled by the Big Tech. Consequently, the three identified mechanisms formed the basis for the discussion, as they bring forward a combination of themes that were previously analyzed in isolation. The analysis of the mechanisms, together with the support from existing literature, show how this research contributes to, builds upon and refines previous research on the topics of collaborative value co-creation, sovereign entity and competitive co-existence. These three topics represent the most important and theoretically significant contributions from this research.

First, *Collaborative Value Co-Creation* extends and deepens prior literature studying the relationship between consumers and technological development in startups. As it has been acknowledged by previous researchers, customers are viewed as co-creators with active participation in providing feedback and contextual information that helps to set the direction for the development of the products (Wecht, 2005; Gassmann et al., 2005; Crupi et al., 2022). More recently, Gupta et al. (2025) found that customer interaction has a particularly significant impact on AI models because data generated through real-world usage can improve directly the performance of that model. However, the existing literature does not exactly address the structural mechanisms through which this co-creation happens within a dependency based ecosystem. Consequently, the collaborative value co-creation theme is shaped by all three mechanisms, while simultaneously enabling them. The findings here indicate that customers do not just provide feedback to the startups, but they are the primary design contributors to the AI products, whose domain knowledge and contextual experience compensate for the resources that the orchestrators could not provide. This is a significant discovery as it reveals a distinct dynamic: while Franco et al. (2024) explain the dependency as flowing downward through the intermediaries toward the final customer in an extractive logic, the results show that instead of reproducing the Big Tech dependency in their customer relationships, startups reverse the logic and make their customer relationship itself the primary source of their strategic autonomy. The customer is not a final link in the dependency chain, but actually becomes the anchor of an alternative value design, where domain knowledge, relational capital and co-created specificity replace the infrastructural, previously valued as the main source of competitive advantage. Therefore, the technological dependency on Big Tech does not cascade downwards, but it is absorbed at the intermediary level and changed into something structurally different through the co-creation process.

Arguably one of the most interesting findings of this research is the idea of the *Sovereign Entity*. The "independent" nature supports and challenges at the same time what has been written in the literature previously. Franco et al. (2024) have suggested a number of reasons for why digital dependencies become deeper over time, resulting in asymmetries that make it increasingly costly and difficult for smaller businesses to separate from their dominant technology companies. Faraj and Leonardi (2022) similarly argued that AI systems exist in "relations of interiority", which means that organisations do not genuinely and fully own their AI models and that they are part of collaborative, distributed systems. By examining these propositions, it is only logical to assume that AI startups become increasingly constrained by their relationships with larger technology companies, eroding their strategic independency as the dependency grows deeper. However, the study's results bring a more nuanced picture of this reality: while recognizing the embedded nature of technology (relying on services such as AWS, LLM APIs and cloud credits), the reliance on these technologies do not impact the startups' overall strategic direction. In fact, perceiving Big Tech as "just an enabler" allows startups to treat infrastructure and strategic direction as two separate and unassociated concepts: the sovereign status is achieved by creating a clear cognitive boundary between infrastructure supplied by Big Tech and the areas in which they maintain ownership of (identity, direction, customer relationships and domain knowledge). Since AI startups engage in close, iterative relationships with their clients and create tailored solutions for them, they sistematically operate in niche marktes that Big Tech finds unattractive due to their lack of efficiency and standardization potentials. Therefore, this niche approach is not incidental, but it is based on the principles of the sovereign orientation. By creating value that is difficult for big companies to imitate or absorb, startups achieve a form of competitive advantage that makes them differentiate from Big Tech while simultaneously reducing customers' incentives to seek solutions from the big providers.

In addition, the *Competitive Co-existence* concept represents a new way of looking at the strategy literature regarding AI startups, therefore making the most distinctive theoretical contribution of this research. Previous studies primarily described the interactions between AI startups and Big Tech as either beneficial alliances that provide technological resources, market access and legitimacy (Gupta et al., 2025; Jacobides et al.2021) or as dependency traps exposing the lock-in effect, governance risks and strategic isolations (Wu & Liu, 2023; Rothstein, 2025). The alliance literature therefore described co-existence as a win-win situation, while the literature on dependency viewed it as a hidden conflict. Neither of them actually captured the ambivalent nature and the holistic, multi-positional orientation of startups within the broader innovation ecosystem.

Consequently, the idea of competitive co-existence describes this exact third perspective. Startups do not see their relationship with Big Tech as either a formal partnership or a dependency trap, but more as an ongoing management of uncertainty. First, they use the infrastructure from Big Tech to be able to function and only after that they unlock the possibility of creating tailored products for their customers. Crucially, this technological necessity is not necessarily resisted or treated as inherently problematic, because as the startups scale and their computational and infrastructural demand intensify, it is only logical that they would be even more reliant on the Big Tech's cloud support as a practical requirement for growth. At the same time, this infrastructural reliance cannot be translated as a strategic alignment, neither as an ideological commitment towards these platforms, as startups are actively exploring risks and alternatives vis-à-vis technological orchestrators. In the European context specifically, it becomes clear that there are real risks associated with the geopolitical situation, differences in regulations and possible access restrictions from the US based technology providers. The recent situation with the new models of Claude Fable 5 and Claude Mythos 5 being initially restricted to foreign nationals due to US governmental export controls (subsequently lifted after a few days) is the perfect example that illustrates the uncertainty and the possible future fragility when it comes to being reliant on the US Big Tech infrastructure (Anthropic, 2026). As a consequence, startups adopt an active orientation towards alternatives: aiming for European-based infrastructure providers, both as a risk mitigation solution and as an expression of sovereign behaviour mentioned previously, or for the long-term ambition to develop

infrastructural capabilities in-house. While the last one still remains aspirational for the early-stage startups that started the business with the Big Tech's infrastructure, the re-orientation attitude itself represents a significant finding, as it implies that the dependency described previously by the literature is not permanent, but rather transitional. Therefore, the competitive co-existence concept is perceived through multiple lenses: simultaneous reliance on larger providers, differentiating themselves from Big Tech and remaining open to continued competition and collaboration.

Ultimately, the new dynamic model aims at extending prior studies by capturing in one place how AI startups define themselves in relation to Big Tech, their own customers, while also showing how they create a distinct place for themselves in the digital ecosystem. AI startups achieve strategic autonomy not through avoidance of dependency, but instead through confining the scope, the basis for anchoring identity in customer relationships (as opposed to platform affiliations) and retaining enough strategic flexibility to be able to reshape the relationship with Big Tech as their company grows. By doing so, the model reframes the current discussion surrounding AI startups from being dependent on Big Tech, to how they actively shape the meaning, boundaries and implications of that reliance, while exploring alternatives.

5.1 Theoretical contributions

This research is set to deepen the knowledge on digital entrepreneurship and the AI ecosystem by developing a relational understanding of dependency in the context of an AI startup. By examining how AI startups relate to the Big Tech industry and customers in their development, the study presents a multi-faceted relational view of dependency as an evolving construct between customers, startups and Big Tech. Prior studies of Big Tech and startups interrelationships have predominantely examained dependency from outside to inside: how specific platform architecture creates lock-ins (Wu & Liu, 2023; Rothstein, 2025), how extractive hierarchies are reproduced at various levels of the ecosystem (Franco et al., 2024) and how the structural asymmetries between Big Tech companies and startups erode the strategic independency of these ventures over time (Rikap, 2024; van der Vlist et al., 2024). Then, these previous papers commonly described dependency as a structural condition observed at the ecosystem level. What they actually did not quite address is what happens inside the startups in terms of managerial practices, relational strategy and identity formation. Therefore, this study's main theoretical contribution is represented by the dynamic model, generated by the Gioia methodology, which ultimately captures the underlying managerial processes and challenges the view of strategic autonomy and dependency on Big Tech as two opposing states. This model proposes three mechanisms for continuous orchestration of technology, customer relationships and ecosystem position for AI startups and describes how these mechanisms allow for co-existence of dependency, collaboration and resistance, all at the same time. Additionally, it also shows how AI startups leverage these tensions through relational and strategic practices. Thus, the dynamic model allows researchers to move beyond simply asking if AI startups are dependent on Big Tech, to examining how they purposefully manage and leverage such reliance.

To be more specific, the theoretical contribution lies in the identification of managerial mechanisms that allow this decoupling (between the infrastructural and strategic dimensions) to take place. Franco et al. (2024) characterized the intermediary position of technology startups as being situated between Big Tech and the end-users, while arguing that this position stimulates the reproduction and further replication of dependency downards. Jacobides et al. (2021) and Oehmichen et al. (2023) examined the structural advantages that comes from being affiliated with Big Tech, from an alliance perspective. The one aspect that neither of these two studies addressed is the micro-level managerial logic through which startups build this intermediary position. Therefore, the three mechanisms completes this missing piece from the big puzzle. In particular, the first mechanism focuses on the way in which startups create relational capital based on their physical presence, community involvement and personal networking, susequently establishing their legitimacy independently from Big Tech. In the third mechanism, startups employ the co-creation dynamic within the competitive identity, using domain knowledge and relationship specificity, the infrastructural layer giving them just a boost on the market. This increases the ventures' competitie advantage, making the niche unattractive for Big Tech firms. Then, the posture of the sovereign entity is not a cognitive phenomenon, but a result of structural conditions established through co-creation. In other words, the customer becomes the source of the strategic independency of the startup instead of being the last link in the extraction chain, which completes the cascade model proposed by Franco et al. (2024).

This leads to the other contribution, namely reframing sovereignty as relational. Prior literature conceptualized that strategic autonomy is either a characteristic that is posssed by a firm or one that is missing, depending on the position of the firm within the ecosystem (Coşkun & Öztürk, 2023). The findings here indicate that sovereignty is therefore developed through relationships rather than being attributed to startups. In relation to the customer, sovereignty emerges from the co-creation process and it is maintained through the relational capital, therefore being achieved through the ecosystem and not against it. This relational understanding of sovereignty connects to but substantially extends the work of Coşkun and Öztürk (2023), by specifying the relational mechanisms through which these boundaries are constructed and maintained.

5.2 Practical implications

As we currently noticed from the literature, startups are relying on networks and partnerships for getting access to resources and a wide variety of customers, they are going through a lot of uncertainty and they are usually operating through trial-and-error processes in order to succeed on the market (Ibrahim et al., 2024; Sommer et al., 2009). On that account, through the results of this research we strive to derive strategies and additions to what existing literature had already stated, in relation to breaking this kind of uncertainty when it comes to managing relationships within the broad tech ecosystem. From a practical perspective, this study provides a dynamic framework that is beneficial for AI startup founders, managers or other tech stakeholders. It aims at informing them about the Big Tech dependency and how it can be managed, while building and sustaining customer relationships. Therefore, through the three mechanisms identified, the model is uncovering a set of managerial processes that translates expectations and pressure from the company environment into coordinated actions within it:

The first mechanism highlights the importance of customers and how this relationship must be managed through an evolutionary process rather than as separate transactions. Startups should create legitimacy through industry presence, attending trade shows and industry conferences in order to develop visibility and

trust. After establishing those, entrepreneurs should concentrate on continuous communication, customer feedback and long-term management of relationships instead of simply focusing on customer acquisition. Transparency regarding the AI models and usage and adherence to data protection rigours are also very important actions that startups should implement from the beginning, as a strategy for building a long-term relation with the users. These coordinated actions foster an environment in which customers become active participants in product development, allowing startups to further refine and improve their offerings, based on actual end-user requirements.

The second mechanism reveals that startups should move away from perceiving Big Tech solely as a source of dependency or competitive threat. Therefore, the entrepreneurs should strategically leverage the cloud and foundation models and the infrastructure as a whole to their advantage, while remaining open to the wide variety of ecosystem complementors. By continuously reviewing alternative technology partners and options rather than committing to a single supplier, startups can avoid lock-in risks while also maximizing customer-driven innovation potential. Thus, embedding technologies into their businesses becomes a strategic asset instead of a risk.

The last mechanism reveals that achieving strategic autonomy is not through distancing from the industry's orchestrators, but instead through strengthening the unique positioning in the market. Thus, entrepreneurs need to focus their resources on specific market segments as opposed to offering multiple products. By doing so, entrepreneurs manage to develop unique capabilities in the co-development process with their customers, as well as distinct knowledge that Big Tech cannot easily replicate. In the end, cultivating these unique capabilities, allows startups to choose more deliberately their technology providers and be in charge of their strategic direction.

Altogether, founders can apply these mechanisms as a set of systematic, sequential processes to coordinate various types of relationships not only in the AI industry, but also in other digitally intense industries. As various businesses are starting to depend on external digital infrastructure, platform providers and collaborative partnerships, they are likely face the same issues in terms of technological uncertainty and dependency, managing customer relations and gaining strategic independency. As a consequence, the dynamic model may serve as a broader managerial framework, that can help entrepreneurs in understanding the relational nature of the ecosystem they are operating in.

6. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE OUTLOOK

While this research offers relevant insights about how AI startups interact with the broader digital ecosystem, there are still some limitations to be recozgnized.

The first one is that the research was conducted using a small sample of AI startups founders and employees, all of them operating on European soils. Even if this sample managed to provide an adequate amount of rich and grounded data for supporting the Gioia methodology, it also limited the generalizability of the findings. The European regulatory environment, heavily influenced by the EU AI Act, the EU General Data Protection Regulation and the strong influence on digital sovereignty (Tomada, 2022), might have had an effect on how these participants viewed their relationship with Big Tech, their attitude towards other providers and how much importance they placed on strategic independency (Smirnova & Victoriano Travieso-Morales, 2025). In other geographic regions, such as the United States where the regulatory environment is totally different and the cultural orientation towards Big Tech is also stronger and more accessible, the perspectives of the participants may vary significantly from the European ones. Future research may involve conducting additional fieldwork in several other locations or comparative analyses of different regional institutions (US-based startups, Asian ventures, etc), to identify how the institutional, regulatory and cultural contexts shape the mechanisms outlined in this research, particularly the sovereign entity posture and the competitive co-existence orientation.

Secondly, all the startups that were interviewed were still in their early stage of development. Therefore, the mechanisms identified were created based on early customer acquisition and retention initiatives, as well as early market penetration and niche positioning. Therefore, it is likely that the nature and strength of dependency on Big Tech to change significantly as startups grow, get more institutional funding or achieve maturity with respect to their product. A startup that is dependent on cloud credits and LLM APIs at the development stage may pursue different (technological) directions once the credits expire. Hence, future research could adopt a longitudinal design and include startups that are situated in different stages of development in order to study the influence of these mechanisms over time and whether the orientation towards sovereignty would remain unchanged or be reduce with better operational complexity (Polyhart & Vanderberg, 2009).

Finally, the study captured only one side of the story, namely the perspective of the AI startups. The overall insights reflect the way AI startups narrate their relationship with the larger orchestrators, but they do not account for how Big Tech themselves perceive these relaionships and respond to the startups operating within their ecosystem. Even if analysing the startups' perspective was the primary goal from the beginning, as the researcher wanted to extend the current studies which mainly focused on the broader orchestrators and their influence in the industry, the mechanisms carry an inherent perspectival bias. They paint a picture of the ecosystem that is lived by the startups, which may be quite different from the one understood by the other actors involved. It remains then an open conceptual question if the orchestrators view this relationship as one of mutual ambiguity or if the end-users perceive the collaborative process as a truly mutual one. Therefore, future work could broaden the scope of this research and conduct interviews with representatives of Big Tech companies, especially with those responsible for customers and startups relations, innovation programs and ecosystem strategies. Similarly, future work could also include interviews with the customer base, to analyze how the relational embeddedness dimension is experienced by the users and whether the co-creation role is mutual.

7. CONCLUSIONS

In the end, this study examined how AI startups navigate their relationships with the Big Tech industry, customers and the broader digital ecosystem. Through a Gioia methodology approach, the findings reveal that these relationships are not independent but continuously co-evolve through three interconnected mechanisms. The first one demonstrates that technological embeddedness and collaborative value co-creation reinforce one another, enabling startups to leverage external technological resources while simultaneously enhancing customer value. The second mechanism highlights a process of relational deepening, where legitimacy enhancement and

relationship continuity transform customers from buyers into active co-developers. Finally, the third mechanism shows how collaborative value co-creation, sovereign positioning and strategic resistance allow startups to preserve strategic autonomy while remaining embedded within the ecosystem.

Overall, this study shows that the relationship between the reliance on Big Tech and being strategically autonomous is not a mutually exclusive one, because AI startups continuously coordinate their infrastructure, customers and ecosystem positioning. The dynamic model ultimately illustrates that the driving force behind success in the AI ecosystems is not to escaping Big Tech dependency, but orchestrating interdependent relationships successfully. The purpose of this research is to highlight the importance of shifting from the question of whether or not AI startups are dependent on Big Tech, to determining how are they leveraging and managing these dependencies in order to remain innovative, competitive and relevant in in the industry.

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9. AI DISCLAIMER

Generative AI was used in developing parts of this thesis. Tools such as Claude or ChatGPT were used for idea and paragraph structuring, organizing the findings in a coherent and logical way and grammar correction. Yet, the researcher remained the final decision-maker regarding the content and the accuracy.

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11. APPENDIX A

Interview guide:
Introduction questions:

1. Could you briefly describe your company, your role and what are the AI solutions that you are currently developing?
2. In which stage is your company currently at? (e.g., early-stage, scaling, etc)
3. Who are your main customers? What are the “issues” that your company is solving for them?

Top-oriented questions:

4. Is your business currently surviving/operating with the help from the Big Tech industry? If so, how and for which activities or products do you use that help?
5. How do you usually choose to partner up with Big Tech? Could you quickly walk me through this process?
6. (How dependent do you feel on the Big Tech industry?)
7. How do external platforms influence your product roadmap or strategic decisions?
8. Have you ever adapted your product or strategy to better fit a platform ecosystem? Can you recall a moment where this clearly shaped a decision you made?
9. How important is the Big Tech industry for reaching customers or partners?
10. How do you typically gain and build relationships with your customers? Could you briefly walk me through these processes?
11. What role do customers play in shaping your products or services?
12. How do you create trust with customers, especially given the complexity of AI and the existence of Big Tech companies?
13. How do you communicate with customers about how your AI works?
14. How do you handle concerns related to data, ethics or control?
15. How does your reliance on external platforms influence your relationship with customers?
16. How do you maintain control over your product or customer relationships?
17. How do you manage the balance between relying on Big Tech and staying independent? Are there any strategies that you are currently following?
18. How would you describe your company’s position within the broader digital ecosystem?
19. How do you acquire the desired capabilities if you are not using the help from Big Tech? Could you briefly describe the strategies behind?
20. How do you see your relationship with Big Tech evolving in the future?

12. APPENDIX B

Gioia Analysis table

Interviewee number	Quotes	First-order codes	Second-order themes	Aggregate dimensions
I07	"They are very dependent on big tech, I would say. They have their application and services running on the Amazon Cloud. Their thing works by making API calls to LLM providers, OpenAI or Anthropic"	Dependency on Big Tech through the applications and services running through their platforms	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I05	"For early stage, they don't give you any sort of benefit other than the infrastructure."	Big Tech does not provide any benefit other than the infrastructure for the early-stage startups	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I05	"But for now, I think that infrastructure is too hard to manage, so we are okay to support the costs"	Infrastructure is too hard to manage	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I06	"I wouldn't say surviving because of big tech. We are getting support on many different levels by big tech"	Startups are getting support from Big Tech, not surviving because of them	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I07	"They don't have their own in-house stuff running."	No in-house AI	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I07	"I wouldn't say they're directly partnering up. They are customers of Big Tech, right?...So, we are their customers, basically, we are not collaborating with them directly."	They are the customers of Big Tech, not collaborating with them directly	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I07	"I would say very dependent, completely dependent. At this stage, because they don't really have their own servers and stuff, so they couldn't be able to operate without the tech services."	They are very dependent on the Big Tech's infrastructure as they could not operate without it	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I04	"We found a company that literally does nothing but exactly providing companies like us that have a hardware solution with also the AI part	Other company provides the hardware solutions; 'solving a lot of issues'	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration

	of it and a really reliable one. Of course, it costs us more to work with them, but it solves us so many issues than we are deciding now"			
I04	"But I think in every process that you want to do, if it's coding, marketing, or whatever, you always get hit by them because that's the best solution"	Every process is influenced by Big Tech	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I08	"So that way we do not plan, for example, I don't know, to try to build the infrastructure that we already have from AWS to build it ourselves. It can become a nightmare. We need loads of resources and we prefer to keep those resources in order to scale the products"	Not trying to build another infrastructure since they already have it from Big Tech	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I08	"but let's say tomorrow AWS will not work, then we cannot onboard anymore customers"	Startups cannot onboard clients anymore if Big Tech does not work anymore	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I09	"yes, we do take advantage of big tech companies. To give a specific example is we are a small company that of course needs a lot of hosting, but also server power and large language model power. So we don't have the capacity to buy our own servers or CPUs. So then we take advantage of, for example, AWS, which is a service by Amazon that basically hosts all of our technical operations for them. And this is the biggest one."	Lack of capacity for supporting their own infrastructure	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I09	"maybe partnership is a big word for this. We do basically take advantage of services that they offer. So they basically just go through an agreement between our company and them. The most common use is indeed the servers."	Startups are making agreements with Big Tech, not partnerships	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I09	"the reason we chose them is because they do offer a very secure platform. And of course, for an application like healthcare, it's quite critical to ensure security."	Big Tech offers a secure platform	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I09	"there's quite a bit of incentives for that they offer for startups to basically receive credits in order to use their services for cheaper or for free for a period of time. So in our case, that was very strategic because of course, we're a startup at the early stage that we want to take advantage of these opportunities"	Big Tech supports with credits	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration

I09	“we don't feel other type of dependency. I think it's mostly operational in our case.”	Operational dependency	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I10	“if not 100%, we're definitely above 90% dependent on them”	Feeling dependent on Big Tech almost 100%	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I10	“I wouldn't call them collaborations because we basically just buy their products”	Not direct collaboration, just buying their products	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I11	“Yes, short answer is yes, we are hosting all our infrastructure on AWS.”	The entire infrastructure is hosted by Big Tech	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I11	“The reason for this being I used to work at Amazon Web Services in the past, so I used to be one of the early employees in Switzerland… and once I decided to create my own startup, I took all the best practices and learnings from Amazon and used it internally.”	The founder worked for Big Tech before so he took all the practices and learnings in terms of infrastructure and implemented in his startup	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I11	“The main reason initially was the expertise that we have. So I knew the infrastructure in and out (…) so I knew the technology very well and I knew what is capable of”	The founder knew the infrastructure from Big Tech very well and what it was capable of	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I11	“It's also a way to develop in a super fast way without actually spending a lot of resources. So you can automate things quite a lot and you know you pay only for the consumption of the resources (….) it's very cost efficient at the very beginning”	Having the infrastructure from Big Tech is cost efficient and fast, especially at the very beginning	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I11	“On top of this, all the big tech companies, but especially Google and Amazon, they have these startup programs. So once you receive funding from a VC they offer you credits, which you can use basically to pay your infrastructure”	Big Tech have startup programs where they can receive credits and have the infrastructure paid for	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I12	“so throughout the many, many features and products that I build, not necessarily at the start, the last startup, but throughout my career as an entrepreneur, I went through all of the big infrastructure companies. I think about Google Cloud Platform, AWS”	Throughout the career and the startup, the entrepreneur went through Big Tech for the infrastructure	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I12	“because they are using the infrastructure provided by the Amazons of the world and so on and so forth, they benefit, which is a win-win kind of situation. “	Using the infrastructure provided by Big Tech is a win-win situation	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I12	“It's almost as if they are investing in the success of your startup by giving you initially the credits. Now, of course, we	It is almost like Big Tech is investing in the startup’s success by giving	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration

	can debate how is that good? Or how is that bad? And so on and so forth. But that's just the dynamic and it seems to work nowadays."	initial credits and it seems to work nowadays		
I12	"when you're building a startup, even when you are a scale-up, meaning you are a product market fit, you're still very much at the mercy of the elements. And in this case, the elements are the big tech."	When you are building a startup, you are at the mercy of Big Tech	Technological Embeddedness	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I10	"So what usually would be Amazon for AWS and hosting, we use Super Base (…) we kind of grew up as well with the new kids on the way"	Using Super Base instead of Amazon for hosting	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I10	"I think it's mostly because of our developers and then it's easier to develop and build products with Cursor"	It is easier to develop and build products on Cursor	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I03	"we made sure our whole IT architecture was as simple and clean and independent as possible."	IT architecture is 'simple, clean and as independent as possible'	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I01	"We want to go in a place where they don't have access currently"	Running away from Big Tech	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I01	"Because there is this EU AI Act, there are some requirements, but there are not that many companies, so there are a few companies that can offer this kind of, let's say high level of requirements which they have there, right? So, that that's let's say our target, and in a way if the big tech would have that, of course we would like to use it, but they don't have it. So that's mainly something that we are building some new capabilities there, right?"	Big Tech does not have the desired level of capabilities	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I03	"we had partnerships with Orange, with Apple and so on, but it wasn't to use their tech, it was because they had specific programs for startups. Outside of those partnerships, which included mentorship and, you know, this kind of stuff, outside of that, all our choices were driven by simplicity, scalability, and data sovereignty."	Big tech is helping with programs for startups, not with the technology	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I02	"And that's precisely why we took the harder, longer path in our development, just to make it more sustainable and to develop our model mature enough so as not to be easily	Taking a harder path for not being swallowed by other companies	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration

	swallowed within the vision of another company"			
I01	"But basically now we have access to the supercomputer from the European Union area (…) so there is no need for, let's say, big tech, right? So we managed to build something on European soil without the need necessarily from Google or NVIDIA or Microsoft or all this stuff"	Access to supercomputers from EU and therefore no need for Big Tech	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I06	"we don't rely on funding or anything from big tech right now. I mean, we have funding from our investors, but they are not like big tech companies"	Big tech does not support the fundings	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I05	"Yeah, honestly, they shape our whole architecture, right? Because we need to work within the ecosystem with what we build"	Big tech shapes the entire architecture	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I05	"However, because we are locked in with Microsoft and we cannot use the credits from Microsoft with ClickHouse"	Locked in with Big Tech	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I08	"they made it in such a way that you need to rely on them"	Big Tech is arranging in such a way that startups need to rely on them	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I11	"at the very beginning, our whole footprint was hyper specific to the cloud provider. Now, it's becoming more generic and the reason for this is we are starting to run a lot of AI workloads and these are deployed on containers which are more like a standard, so you can migrate them from one provider to the other with a decent effort"	The startup's footprint was hyper specific to Big Tech at the beginning, but now they started to run the AI model on standard containers which allows for mitigating from one provider to the other effortlessly	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I07	"they could use Google Cloud if they wanted, it would be exactly the same"	They can use other providers for the infrastructure and would be exactly the same	Strategic resistance/autonomy	AI startups and Big Tech orchestration
I10	"So for us, what worked very well, it's our investors doing referrals and intros for us"	Referrals from investors worked for acquiring customers	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I10	"it's like the network of the founders, firstly"	Founders' own network as a primary source of getting customers	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I10	"it's accountants they've been working with and then they got the interest from there. And then those accountants trust them already, and they're open to at least see a demo"	Accountants have previously worked with the founders so they trust them to at least see a demo	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness

I02	“And then of course, we brought our own networks into the business.”	Bringing their own networks	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I01	“So last year we had a presentation in the in a conference that was in Bucharest. It was called [name of the conference] (…)On the other hand, we knew each other from before through the online channels, but we established a bit more partnership during that period”	Establishing partnerships at conferences	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“Our strategy is a lot of conferences or networking events that are dedicated for this market. So, for example, there is a [name of the congress] that happens once per year, and we're usually present there”	The strategy consists of conferences and networking events	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I07	“they find the people and they call and then they arrange meetings. That seems to be the strategy”	Arranging meetings with potential customers	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“Another strategy that's similar to this, we recently published a paper in a biobanking journal. So actually putting our name out there as experts in AI, but specifically in this field, also builds credibility.”	Publishing in journals for building creditibility	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“And then of course in these events we do get a lot of context and then we explore further if there's an overlap or not (...) So do they need support with patients on site or do they want a tool that can be used from home? Do they want to collect data or do they only want to have a chat agent that can answer questions?”	Attending events for exploring further customer needs and requests	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I03	“Even before bringing and testing out solutions, we started, it was very important to have a relationship with the local NGOs, national NGOs, then looking also at other countries. And then with researchers and therapeutics that would be users themselves.”	Establishing connections with local communities	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I03	“Then we were present in all major conferences, trade shows around autism and mental health, workshops, many, many workshops. And we realized soon after that it was extremely important to be there when they install everything and to actually do training sessions”	Being present at the most important conferences and workshops around autism and mental health	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness

I05	“And I never do cold call, although I do it, but I don't do it to sell. If I do a cold outreach, I do it purely socially to people on LinkedIn and trying to connect with them rather than trying to sell them something”	Cold calling for establishing a connection	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I04	“I go there in person. I go to events that they host, especially as we are now only in the Berlin area. I have the privilege to be there. And I go to every event I possibly can where I know that there's a chance they're going to be there. And I literally start forming connections like that.”	Physical presence at events	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I05	“So usually most of my clients, it goes through my network”	Own network	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I06	“We have different funnels of, firstly, we have ads.”	Different funnels	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I06	“So we are on the fair and then they come up to us and they're like, oh, I think I've heard of you. What are you doing exactly?”	Engagement at fairs	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I06	“So that's why we're traveling through whole of Germany to different fairs of tax advisors. Like we've been on like, I think, 5 fairs this year already, and there's like a lot more coming.”	Physical presence at fairs	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“we're not using really big tech to reach out to customers now…because we work in agriculture (…) it's a very specific area, niche area”.	Big Tech is not used for reaching out to customers because of the niche market, where Big Tech does not operate	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“One of the co-founders actually is from this industry, so obviously he already had a network”	The co-founder had already the suitable network since operating in the industry	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“with the fairs, we expanded our network and now we know more or less the majority of the operators”	Expanding the network with attending fairs	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“it was not through big tech, it was mostly us, reaching out to them or through our existing network”	Reaching out new customers through already existing network, not through Big Tech	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“Think about Facebook, think about Instagram, LinkedIn, and even Google Search, YouTube…so you do rely on them, not only for the tech, but also for the customers, or at least a distribution channel towards your customer. Of course, reliant…it's a spectrum because it's one thing to just	Big Tech brings in the distribution channels that are crucial for reaching out to customers	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness

	rely on Google and Google alone.”			
I12	“I think the most important one is through my own network and through introductions. I'm asking for intros to different type of customers that fall within the, let's say, the ideal client profile, and then I start the conversation, and then if that conversation leads to something more meaningful, then we enter in some sort of commercial agreement. Otherwise, we just keep in touch and you never know.”	Own network and introductions to different types of customers that fall into the ideal client profile	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“cold outreach, LinkedIn outreach and advertising”	“cold outreach, LinkedIn outreach and advertising”	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“I've also had customers that saw some of my blog posts or some of my articles that I published and then they reached out and, hey, let's have a conversation. I'm interested in this, this, and that. We have this problem with our company. How would you approach it? Is there anything that you can do to help us?”	Customers reached out after seeing blog posts and articles written by the founder	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“Another way is going to conferences and meetups, just meeting people like that.”	Attending conferences and meetups for meeting potential customers	Legitimacy Enhancement	Relational Embeddedness
I02	“Through commitment and delivery, I guess, our research, our outputs can be, first of all, they're explainable. Unlike other systems, they're fully, they're explainable, so that's always a plus.”	Through commitment and explainability	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“So they're not as interested in the technicalities of the AI, but rather in the privacy.”	Customers are not interested in technicalities, but rather in privacy	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“But I would say to generalize, a lot of the customers are not per se interested in the very technical details of like what is the actual framework behind how it works, where it goes, what resource that it uses, but rather an important question for them is privacy. So basically they want to know at which points in time does the data is the data anonymized or encrypted, so they make sure that, because it can be very sensitive data, this is not being exposed to a model or like to a basically an open resource”	Customers are not interested in technicalities, but rather in privacy	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness

I06	“That's just where you get your customers and how you build a relationship because they also want to be very close. So they are not there and saying like, oh, I buy any random product. They're like, oh, why do I want you? And then they want, they need to like you.”	Customers are interested in establishing a close relationship	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I10	“they seem to trust us because they see how fast we solve their problem (…) we saved them so many hours”	Startup saved a lot of hours for the customers so that is why they are trust worthy	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I10	“we show people that we're not sending their data anywhere, we're not looking at it, we don't even see what they've been doing inside their chats (…) and they know this”	Customer data is not shared or seen by the startup and the users are aware of that	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I10	“And they are the ones asking for them, definitely”	Customers ask for data protection	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I10	“we have recurrent meetings with them and then we go into their offices because it's like, it's like with babies. You need to show them how this works”	Recurrent meetings with customers and visits to their offices to show them how to use the AI product	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I06	“we have to be very GDPR compliant and very secure about what we're storing and how we're storing it. So all the data we're storing is encrypted and so we're trying to store as little as data as needed.”	Adherence to regulations and data protection rigours	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I06	“And that makes us really close to the customers, so they mostly like us. And that's also continuing on the customer afterwards. So when we are in contact with them, it's always one person who's responsible for the customers who sends out all the emails.”	Constant contact with customers	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I01	“The trust is coming from transparency on how you take decisions, how you got to these decisions within your AI systems. So our AI and the models that we are using are not necessarily a black box, and this is basically the problem which we want to solve. We want to offer some models, some decisions within our algorithms, which can be explained.”	‘Trust is coming from transparency’	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I05	“They try to just, you know, pick the phone of their customers and then try to sell you immediately, and that's why they don't sell.”	Just calling and trying to sell immediately does not work	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I04	“I talk with them. I was like, how is the experience? What do you think of this?	Interest in customer experience	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness

I04	“Always trying to build a product around their needs.”	Building the product around the customer needs	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“but on a higher level, we basically make sure that the data that we get is pseudo-anonymized. We also have different guardrails at different points in our framework to make sure that this is not being used. We avoid errors basically with this. We also have insurance against any kind of leakage.”	Making sure that the data is pseudo-anonymized	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“Usually, clients don't per se ask. They just want to make sure that, even if the data is posted, technically it's not exposed to the big tech. So because of these steps before about pseudonymization, these are the data doesn't per se reach AWS in the same format that it reaches us. So they do ask that this is the case and they can ask for proof and depending on the client, they do or do not”	Customers place value on the data security	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“The only relevance is that it's within the European Union because they are healthcare institutions, then we need to actually demonstrate to them. So if they do need to see this, then we have basically where our servers are in Europe, or like the AWS servers are in Europe.”	Customers have access to their data tracks and journey	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I03	“we had to carry many, many experiments to make sure that the tool is customizable enough so that it's well prepared for many kinds of perceptual profiles.”	Customizable products for a wide range of clients	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I03	“communication was generally an important part (…) we tried to be everywhere to make sure we can be contacted in case they need help.”	Communication as key	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I03	“I think that presence was something that was extremely valued and was a big driver in knowing that the tool would be used in the long term.”	Presence as a big driver for long-term usage	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I08	“we did and we actually do some cold outreach campaign, 1st of all, and through recommendation. We haven't tried ads yet, but cold outreach actually works pretty well for us.”	Cold outreach	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I02	“We are fully compliant, not only with the EU AI Act, but also with the data protection rigor across the EU and other	Fully compliant with regulations, as part of the	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness

	localities (…) and that's precisely what's being tested at us and assessed in this process, so it's like kind of like no way out (…) this type of compliance is embedded. It's not an afterthought. It's part of how the system works. And it's been our proposition and objective from the very beginning"	proposition and not an afterthought		
I05	"only a handful of people will have access to manage the data sets. It's very restricted."	Data is very restricted	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I08	"We have a dashboard where we can see all the risks that comes into data privacy and we try to protect them as much as possible; we keep them pretty pre-isolated."	Dashboard with data and risks; 'keeping them isolated'	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I08	"So each client has a container information that can be easily deleted based on their request"	Client can see their information via requests	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I08	"So we listen to them what they need"	Active listening	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I08	"we most likely have a weekly call with each of our clients. We try to listen to them as much as possible and as well they consistently provide us feedback. We have different channels, some of them more direct, some of them more formal, and for example, WhatsApp groups, we have as well, they have our emails. "	Weekly calls with clients for getting feedback	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I05	"So I am always trying to gain the trust by spending time with them, by going out, by trying to learn about who they are and what problems they have."	Spending time with clients and learning about their problems and needs	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I05	"I never sell and I'm trying not to help them, genuinely."	Trying to help the customers geniuenly	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I04	"the clients that we currently have, I always text them, I always go to their clubs, make sure everything is working well."	Always texting the customers, 'make sure that everything is working well'	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I09	"So in our case, we do very much know the pain points of our clients and also why they haven't either done it themselves or why they haven't looked at big tech to do these things for them. And then actually keeping this as a competitive advantage is more the survival strategy, let's say, in this domain."	Understanding the customers' "pains' as a competitive advantage	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness

I11	“if working with big tech has an impact on the trust in us, you know, by customers, I don't think so. I mean, everybody's using big tech in one way or another. So I don't think that changes in any way their perspective.”	Working with Big Tech does not have an impact on customers’ trust in the company	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“So there are different mechanisms we implement, you know, to increase trust in different ways, but one of them is also to be transparent around sources that you use”	There are many mechanisms implemented to increase trust but one of them is to be transparent around the used sources	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“So the users can influence the software to adopt their growing philosophy, their contextual information, and so on. So, in the end, it slowly becomes a digital twin of themselves, the image in the mirror. So, and if this is the case, if it follows their guidelines, they trust it also more.”	The software adopts the customer behaviours and contextual information, becoming a digital twin and increasing the chances to be trusted more	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“Contact. And contact is more on a personal level, so we talk to each of them, we visit them, I mean, on-site visits happen also often. In this industry, personal contact is quite important.”	On-site visits and personal contact is important for keeping customers close	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“it's critical for founders, entrepreneurs, business people to really understand and dig deeper into understanding the customer problem and see if there's something that you can do about it.”	It’s critical for entrepreneurs to dig deeper into understanding the customer problem and try to find a solution	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“Trust is a very important component with or without AI…trust that is embedded in your team then relates to the trust to the external trust building with a customer.”	Trust is a very important component and it comes from the team first, then it is translated to the customers	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“And so I think trust with customers begins with trust within the team. I wholeheartedly believe that because I've seen it crumble from within. Because at the end of the day, we're talking	Customer trust begins with the trust within the team because we are all humans and trust is a ‘inherently	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness

	about business and customers, but these are abstract entities. At the end of the day, we are all human. And trust is inherently a human characteristic.”	human characteristic’		
I12	“so you have to talk to the customer and be consultative rather than selling your own product, you know, and explaining the spectrum between the negative and the positive. Zero trust or full trust, right? Because we each play within this spectrum. But it's hard. It takes a long, long time to build trust, which you can lose very quickly.”	Talking to customers and being consultative rather than just selling the product, because it takes a long time to build trust and you can lose it very quickly	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“you are reliant on on big tech on platforms such as YouTube, Google, whatever, Reddit, Facebook, LinkedIn, you name it. But then, once you acquire a customer, then the control moves mostly in your company, right?”	The control after acquiring a customer lies in the startup, even if Big Tech represented a way for acquiring the customer	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“but the moment that the customer signs with you, you are responsible for that relationship.”	The startup is responsible for customer relationship once the customer signed with the startup	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I12	“making sure you have a streamlined communication, constant communication with your customer. Customers can reach out to you in case something bad happens and you're able to respond timely to any incidents and stuff like that.”	Making sure the constant communication with customers is available, to make sure they can reach out in case of incidents	(Relationship) continuity	Relational Embeddedness
I02	“So we do shape each other (…) like it's been a natural…organic path in this development simply because we work in this collaborative environments”	Shaping each other in a collaborative environment	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I05	“when they are listened, they are sharing with you exactly the things that they want, right? They are trying to be nice and tell you that, okay, you have a nice product. But yeah, I think the most important factor is to build for them and to identify customers that they give you the right advice. You don't want customers to tell you that you are a perfect product, because you're not.”	When customers are listened, they are sharing their honest opinions, the right advice	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness

I12	“it's a kind of like a co-development relationship, whereas if they require something that you do not have, then you're trying to understand what exactly is the problem that prompts them to ask”	It’s a co-development relationship with customers where you are trying to understand what they require and you do not have	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I02	“we also developed the model iteratively and gradually based on the experience, based on the feedback, based on the inputs from our project partners, clients.”	The model is developed iteratively, through feedbacks and inputs	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“then we propose basically a project for them in the sense that our chatbots have a standard framework, which we then customize based on that specific customer. And that usually goes with the two-month development or adjustment of the development to make it customizable for them. And then we offer a two-month pilot together with them at a discounted price in order to determine if basically what we developed for them fits what they were looking for. And only afterwards we either think, we either decide there needs to be some redevelopment that has to happen or this is a product that can directly go to a larger amount of of users.”	Offering pilot project and development checkings with the customers	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“the customer is the one that dictates the features that they need or want in addition to our standard framework.”	The customer is the one that dictates the features	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I09	“So we really treat this as a co-development relationship rather than we know best and we give it to you.”	Co-development relationship	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I03	“we were extremely, extremely interested in their feedback, so we tried to give as much space as possible in this many channels where we could retrieve the feedback. or engage them as much as possible to send their feedback and make it public if possible”	Big interest in the customer feedback and opening many channels for retrieving the feedback	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I08	“The most important role, to be honest, because we focus on them totally. Even though if sometimes it might be a mistake or if they try to incline us into the wrong direction, but yeah, we listen to them. They are the experts in the industry”	The customer plays the most important role	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness

I06	“they play the main role of where we get to, in a sense of, we rely a lot on customer feedback. I think if you don't rely on customer feedback, you're just guessing and then you could also just flip a coin.”	Relying a lot on customer feedback	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I06	“And also most of our feedback comes from fears, because we talked to them, we were like, okay, what are the issues? How can we improve?”	Improvement based on listening to customers ‘fears’	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I07	“they have a lot of calls with customers that they're building the pilot suite, and then it's very iterative, like they build the other feature of their thing, and then… in the meetings they give feedback.”	They constantly collaborate with customers for developing the product and asking for their feedback	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“I mean, most the vast majority of the features and services we're launching is based on customer feedback…we use this feedback to drive our product roadmap”	The majority of features and services is based on the customer feedback	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I11	“We are more dependent than our customers, yes, because if you want to add these kinds of value-added services, especially in the AI space, you need to work with them”	More dependent on the customers because of the value-added services	Collaborative value co-creation	Relational Embeddedness
I02	“coming with a different vision, with a different ethical approach as well”	A different vision and a different ethical approach	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	“we're hosting the AI (…) the usage and the servers have less to do with the strategic decision of the provider that we're using. So in our case, I would say that there's not a huge dependency on that or influence on the strategic choices there.”	The servers have less to do with the strategic decision of the provider	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I06	“external products don't really affect our timelines, our roadmaps. I mean, not directly, maybe, of course, indirectly”	External products do not affect the product road maps	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I05	“I think it's actually good to work with big tech from a reputation standpoint if you use it. Some startups, they might use the name, oh, we are working with Microsoft, we are working with Google as a coin, as a negotiation coin to increase their reputation or trust. We don't do that that much.”	Not displaying the Big Tech names for reputation	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I02	“Bold, ambitious, probably with a unique proposition from a systems architecture perspective as well.”	Bold, ambitious and with an unique proposition	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn

I02	“And also through our experience, because whereas we come from very different domains, we make a very good team.”	Different backgrounds of expertise	Sovereign entity	
I08	“We do the hard work. They are just enablers that at the end of the day, they want to sell your product. They allow you to build on top of their infrastructure and products and then the big bill comes up.”	Big Tech is an enabler, ‘we do the hard work’	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I08	“But as well at the same time, we try to run as lean as possible”	Trying to run as lean as possible	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	“I think we're offering an alternative that really is not a one-size-fits-all solution, but rather a co-development customized solution, which big tech will most likely never be interested in because it's not scalable.”	Offering an alternative that is not ‘a one-size-fits-all solution’	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I03	“we started as a pure digital tool that then transformed into something much bigger because the needs were much bigger.”	Started as a pure digital tool and then grew much bigger because of the demand	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I01	“We want to offer some models, some decisions within our algorithms, which can be explained.”	Explainable models	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I05	“So yeah, we're trying to run away from the hype of just using AI for the marketing reason, and we're trying to make AI at the core of the platform to be used in something which is generally used for AI, not just mention that is AI.”	Using AI in the business model for the sake of AI, not just for the name	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I04	“we want the whole experience to feel as natural and as easy as possible instead of what, you know, big startups are trying to be nowadays and like everything is AI and everything is a LLM, everything is a chatbot. These are sports people at the end of the day. We want their experience to be very flawless and very human”	Looking forward a natural and easy experience, not ‘everything is a chatbot’	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I01	“I mean, you would say that it's a small start, but with a lot of big perspective. So it's not another fancy name with some fancy ideas. We want something that it will remain as	‘We want something that will remain as a foundation for what is to come’	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn

	a foundation for what is to come.”			
I06	“it's not the niche for big tech. I mean, big tech mostly invests into companies that they can see a potential in acquiring at some point or are scared to be in their niche”	Too niche for Big Tech	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	“And usually because we're in a very conservative market, customers are afraid to go for these big companies because they are aware that their data can be used or the patient's data can be used. They're concerned about privacy. So actually for them, it's an argument against choosing a company to be one of the big tech ones”	The conservative market represents a reason for which customers are afraid to go for the Big Tech companies	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	“And that's what is attractive for the clients, actually, getting away from big tech.”	Getting away from big tech is attractive for clients	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	“our strategy is usually building a strong network around us with other startups that we know are in very similar or in helpful domains.”	Building a strong network with other startups from the same domain	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I07	“I will describe it as like the company that is reliant on Big Tech to provide a solution that Big Tech does not yet provide for some reason.”	The startup is a company that relies on Big Tech while also delivering a solution that Big Tech does not provide yet	Sovereign entity	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I02	“it depends how we position ourselves within this environment. Maybe as competitors, maybe we'll explore shared solutions moving forward.”	Future positioning within the environment (‘maybe as competitors’ to Big Tech’)	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I02	“That's also part of the process and getting to know about what others do and learn of their experiences. It's a very volatile environment if I'm to be candid.”	Learning from others experiences; volatile environment	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I02	“if I had the tools to redo everything, I would have done many, many things differently”	Trying everything differently	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I08	“If our startup becomes a scalable one, I see a good relationship. One that probably I know. It will become consolidating”	Good relationship in the future if the startup becomes a scalable one	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I05	“I think big tech needs to create much more openings like that where they allow new tech to come and disrupt industries.”	Big Tech needs to create more openings to allow new tech to disruot industries	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I04	“I would say that we're always going to have a relationship. But I think it's inevitable. I	‘We’re always going to have a relationship’ with	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn

	think big tech is the little leech on everybody's startup that as they grow"	Big Tech because is inevitable		
I04	"I would say 100% we're going to become more dependent because as we grow, we're also going to probably get more solutions from other small companies or other startups incorporated that are going to help us with the tasks"	Becoming more dependent on Big Tech 100%	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I06	"So we would still want to keep up that relationship with them. It will be closer. It will be closer the more we go on."	Seeing a closer relationship with Big Tech	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	"we're moving away from at least US-based big tech, which I think is all of them, and more towards a European perspective. So I think also from our side, we're always looking for competitive services that come from European-based companies. So from a strategic point of view, but also a regulatory point of view, we're always on the lookout to move away from big tech."	Moving away from the US-based big tech and moving towards European-based companies	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I09	"So having the strong network around these capabilities is important."	Strong network around capabilities is important	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I02	"both being very active within civil societies, right, and like keeping close partnerships, you know, like not only with institutions, but with activists too. We see it as a different proposition."	Active with social actors such as civil societies, institutions as a different position	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I10	"If we start developing our models, and so we're not going to be so dependent on them"	If their own models will be developed, the startup is not going to be so dependent on Big Tech	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I10	"Can this be done by Anthropic or not? And if it can be done, what are the things they cannot do and we can do?"	Thinking about what the bigger models will be able of not doing and the startups would be	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I11	"we're also looking at diversifying this risk. I mean, not being dependent on one AI provider and we're testing now different alternatives, but it's a risk. Tomorrow the US government might say that the opus model or the new standard model is whatever, too fast, too powerful, and so on and we cannot afford to not run the business anymore. So we need to find ways around	Looking for different alternatives of AI providers due to uncertainty coming from the US government	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn

	that. And we're looking now at open weights models."			
I11	"if we see that some service costs almost the same, we would look at the alternatives and try to diversify this"	If there would be other providers offering the same price for the infrastructure, the startup will take into account other alternatives	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I11	"we will probably look for ways to make sure that no matter what happens, we can continue providing our services, whether this means, maybe going through to multiple providers or have some sort of a backup plan"	Exploring alternatives, including going through multiple providers, in order to make sure that no matter what happens, the startup can continue its activity	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I11	"try to find a strategy to mitigate risks (…) but unfortunately, there's no alternative"	Trying to find a strategy for risk mitigation although right now there is no other alternative than Big Tech	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I12	"today it's interesting because it is no longer just the threat that is coming from the big tech. It used to be before as well, but now, because you can code a website or a platform immediately and have a minimum viable product, the threat also comes from the little guys, from a student in the Netherlands that is using Claude to actually build something. And all of a sudden, you have a new competitor. And so when you build a startup and when you build the strategy, the vision for the product, you also have to take into consideration all of these things"	Big Tech is no longer a threat because there are other people/companies that can become a competitor and you have to take all these things into consideration as an entrepreneur	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I12	"So helping our customers. Our customers' users find products on their e-commerce so that they increase their revenue, they increase their conversion rate, and so on and so forth. And that's the positioning, but you know, when you talk about positioning, you also have to take into consideration the competitors."	The positioning lies in helping the customers but also taking into account the competitors	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn
I12	"what is the nature of my relationship with big tech? Is this really a relationship? What I mean, you know, we have to 1st define what is the nature of this relationship, because I think it's transactional, right, and if it's transactional, then, and it remains objectively	The relationship with Big Tech is mainly transactional and it is alright if it remains like this; the problem is when it interferes with moral spheres	Competitive co-existence	Holistic digital ecosystem perceptionn

	transactional, then I don't see a problem with it. The problem becomes, though, when it interferes, for example, with my moral spheres, dependency spheres as an individual, but also as a company.”			